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Men in Blue look to make it two in a row

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How a love story developed into a deep belonging to India

EXCLUSIVE

N. Ram

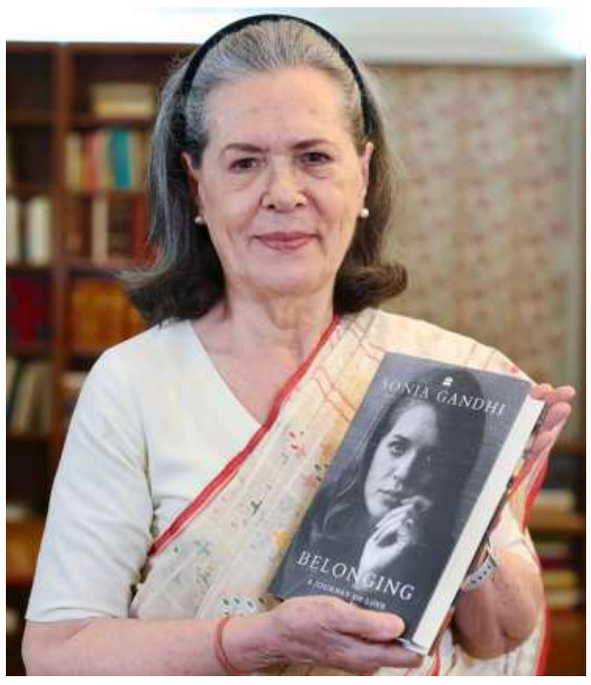
In an interview to *The Hindu* on her soon-to-be-launched book, *Belonging: A Journey of Love,* Sonia Gandhi observed that under the Bharatiya Janata Party-Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh dispensation over the last 12 years, "great damage has been done to the fabric of our country, our democracy and our institutions. Even after this government goes, it will take time to restore our systems back to health, and great effort from political parties. People are now beginning to be restless and recognising the damage. But I am optimistic and I know that the people of India will welcome a return to proper governance."

Asked about the decline of the Congress as India's dominant party, the view of some critics that the party has not been able to reverse the declining trend, and its present condition and prospects, the former Congress President responded: "I am not so pessimistic. Consider that the Congress party and other opposition parties have not had a level playing field since this government came to power. Take into account the complete stranglehold they have on all institutions, especially the Election Commission, their control of mainstream media, their money power and their exploitation of religion. Yet, our party is fighting and making progress... What is more, it has been amply proved in recent months that many elections have been stolen, and people are now more aware of it. The Congress is working with like-minded parties, and our prospects are improving day by day."

Sonia Gandhi's much-awaited *Belonging,* published by HarperCollins India, is a personal memoir, with politics providing the background or "a kind of framework," as she puts it in the book.

I read it as a love story at its heart, the story of an extraordinary, instantly formed bond of love between Rajiv and Sonia, which gradually grew into something much larger, drawing her into his family, into the highest circles of power, then reluctantly into public life and politics, and eventually making her one of the country's foremost political leaders. "Stranger than fiction, isn't it?" I asked her in the interview.

"Yes!", she responded. "That's one reason I had no desire to talk about it for so long. But it is not only a love story between the two of us, it's also the story of how I grew to love Rajiv's family and the country to which they belonged,



Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi unveils her book *Belonging: A Journey of Love.* PTI

and then I too came to belong in it. And of how this love brought me into public life, when I saw the purpose of all the sacrifices they had made being threatened, and the party was weakening. I felt I had to do something."

Rajiv Gandhi and Indira Gandhi, with whom she shared an exceptionally close bond, are the two central figures in Sonia's story. Asked what, looking back, she saw as their defining qualities and how each shaped her life and outlook, she explained: "When I arrived in India as a young bride, I knew nothing about India. All that I am and know today, I learnt from them. Their courage, their empathy, their commitment to a secular and democratic India and most of all, the pull of duty that was greater than any other for both of them was something that inspired me and held me steadfast during times of difficulty and doubt."

Asked how much of the young Italian woman who met Rajiv Gandhi at a Greek restaurant in Cambridge about 60 years ago survives in the Sonia of today, she replied: "The values that I learnt growing up survive... But I used to smile and laugh a lot more then!" She responded in some detail to questions about the Emergency of 1975-1977 as an anti-democratic and authoritarian chapter in the history of independent India; and the response needs to be read in its entirety to understand how she views the Emergency today.

In May 1999, when some party leaders, including Sharad Pawar, raised the issue of her foreign origin and asserted that she could not hold high office in India, she submitted her resignation as Congress President and then withdrew it. Asked about this, Sonia Gandhi responded, "Of course, I felt hurt... It came as a shock that they still saw me as an outsider."

But looking back, she could see "they may have had their own reasons." She added that "after some soul-searching," she realised that "I could not let my personal feelings divert me from my larger purpose. I had to continue."

After the Congress-led victory in the 2004 Lok Sabha election, Sonia Gandhi, the obvious choice of the party and the coalition to become Prime Minister, declined the offer. But under intense pressure in "the surreal drama" that followed, she said "*Theek hai*," only to change her mind. Asked whether she had ever wondered how United Progressive Alliance policies and Congress strategy might have differed had she accepted, she replied emphatically: "No, not at all. That has never crossed my mind. Our experience was by and large a very positive one. We worked as a team, and our roles were distinct with him [Manmohan Singh] leading the government and I leading the party."

INTERVIEW ON » PAGE 4

INSIDE



Kerala Police cuts back on security cover for Vijayan

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
The Kerala Police has downgraded Opposition leader Pinarayi Vijayan's personal security from Z+ to Y category. The decision was made by the security review coordination committee. » PAGE 2

Nifty surges over 6.8% to reclaim the 25,000 mark

MUMBAI
Indian markets marked the biggest rally of 2026 in the first week of November with the Nifty 50 surging more than 6.8% for the week ended November 6 to settle at 25,030.35. The Sensex ended 81,028.02, up 2.17% or 1,718.01 points on Friday. » PAGE 11

Ousted voters in 6 States and Delhi can resubmit enumeration forms, says ECI

- Directive comes after SC questioned why deleted voters were asked to file Form 6
- Activists who challenged the deletion of voters in Delhi SIR have welcomed move
- Jairam Ramesh terms move a belated admission of wrongful voter deletions

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Voters marked as Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate (ASDD) in select States and a Union Territory, where the special intensive revision (SIR) is under way can submit the enumeration form again to get their names included in the electoral rolls, instead of having to use Form 6, which is meant for registration of first-time voters.

These electors were marked as absent because their enumeration forms had been issued but not received, resulting in their exclusion from the draft electoral rolls during the ongoing SIR exercise.

The Election Commission of India's (ECI) directive comes after the Supreme Court, while hearing a petition filed by activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri on October 28 against the deletion of voters during the SIR in Delhi, asked the Commission why the deleted voters were being asked to use Form 6 for re-inclusion in the electoral rolls and why Form 8 could not be used.

In a directive to the Chief Electoral Officers of Delhi, Maharashtra, Haryana, Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, Telangana, and Nagaland on Friday, the ECI said booth-wise lists of all electors marked as ASDD, whose enumeration forms were not received and who could not be included in the draft electoral roll during the SIR, should be displayed afresh on the notice boards of their polling stations. The lists should also mention the probable reasons for the non-inclusion of their names.

A second chance

The ECI allows Absent, Shifted, Dead, and Duplicate-marked voters in seven States/U.T. to resubmit enumeration forms

- The directive covers Delhi, Maharashtra, Haryana, Andhra Pradesh, Jharkhand, Telangana, and Nagaland
- Polling stations will redisplay excluded voters' names and probable reasons for exclusion
- Voters must explain why they missed the earlier deadline; those who moved within the State must provide their new address



- Those who have already submitted Form 6 need not file an enumeration form again

Partially filled enumeration forms for all such ASDD electors will also be generated afresh in the Electoral Registration Officer dashboard in ECINET.

Electors who have not shifted their residence can submit their duly filled-in enumeration forms along with an enclosed statement, mentioning the reason as to why they could not submit their forms earlier.

Those who have shifted residence within the State shall submit the Enumeration Form along with the statement enclosed, indicating their new address and the Assembly Constituency.

Till now, voters whose names were missing from the draft rolls had to submit Form 6 to re-enter the electoral rolls. Form 6 includes a declaration that the said applicant has not been registered as a voter elsewhere. This had led to concerns among many regarding the legality of the process.

The ECI clarified that electors who have already submitted Form 6 need not submit the enumeration form with the statement afresh.

Shortly after the ECI issued the directive, Ms. Bharadwaj and Ms. Johri welcomed the move. "We believe this is an important step in addressing large-scale exclusions caused during SIR. The provision to re-assign the old EPIC numbers is important as it will ensure preservation of voters' historical record of being an existing voter," they said. "Just in Delhi, of 47.56 lakh deleted in the first phase and put on ASDD, 31.59 lakh were marked as permanently shifted and 11.73 as absent/untraceable," they said.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said the move was a belated admission that wrongful deletion and exclusion had indeed taken place under the ASDD category.

"The ECI is carrying out one correction after another after the nationwide outrage over SIR, which has robbed over 13 crore Indians of their constitutional right to vote. Every new set of orders begs the question: what was the point of this bureaucratic mess that every Indian has been put through? These repeated clarifications and amendments actually expose the true intent of the diabolical PM-HM.," he said.

SC says OBC creamy layer ruling is not retrospective

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday clarified that its March 11, 2026 judgment, upholding a 1993 Office Memorandum that excluded parental salary and agricultural income from the income/wealth test for determining OBC non-creamy layer status, did not call for a sweeping revision of service allocations or seniority across successive recruitment years.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and R. Mahadevan, in its order, said the Centre, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, had erred in assuming that a "retrospective implementation of the March 11 judgment would have far-reaching consequences for recruitment, service and cadre allocation, and admissions to Higher Educational Institutions".

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 3

As high as 31% ethanol found in samples of petrol sold by major oil companies

Rashmi Patil
BENGALURU

Petrol sold by major oil companies in Karnataka contained ethanol far above the prescribed 20% level, in some cases as high as 31.2%, the State government has claimed, raising questions about transparency in the ethanol-blended petrol being sold to consumers across the country.

The samples in question were taken recently by the Department of Legal Metrology from Bengaluru Urban, Bengaluru Rural, Kolar, Chikkaballapura, Tumakuru and Dakshina Kannada districts, said Karnataka Minister for Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs Rizwan Arshad on Friday. Petrol samples from major oil marketing companies (OMCs), Indian Oil Corporation Limited (IOCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL), recorded ethanol blend percentages of 31.2% and 30.5%, respectively. Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), Nayara and Shell petrol samples revealed ethanol blends of 26.5%, 26.1% and 25.5%, respectively, he said.

Mr. Arshad said the samples were initially submitted to the in-house laboratories of IOCL and BPCL. But he claimed the test reports issued by these laboratories did not disclose the ethanol content in the fuel, despite it being one of the prescribed testing parameters. "This raises serious concerns about transparency on the part of the oil majors and what they are hiding from consumers," he said.

"The Department of Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs, Karnataka, later got the same samples tested at laboratories recognised by the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories (NABL) and the International Organisation for Standardisation. These reports have revealed higher ethanol blends," Mr. Arshad said.

Fuelling concerns

Sample from OMC outlets	Fuel	Ethanol % in samples collected*
IOCL	Petrol (Motor Spirit)	31.2, 20.8
HPCL	Petrol (MS-Power)	30.5
HPCL	Petrol (MS)	27.0, 22.4
BPCL	Petrol (MS)	24.2, 22.6
BPCL	Petrol (MS-Speed)	26.5
MRPL	Petrol (MS)	19.2
Nayara	Petrol (MS)	26.1, 20.6
Shell	Petrol (MS)	25.5, 13.5

Source: Department of Food and Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs, Karnataka

*Multiple values indicate separate samples of fuel collected from different outlets operated by the same OMC.

However, the three State-owned oil-marketing companies stated the tests were not conducted in accordance with prescribed statutory and technical procedures.

Citing discrepancies with findings from their own quality monitoring, they urged the State government to share the complete sampling documentation, outlet-wise laboratory reports and details about the adopted testing methodology, and samples for retesting.

Consumers suffer

Mr. Arshad said 99% of India's over 35 crore vehicles are not built for ethanol blends of more than 20%, and the risk is not limited to old vehicles."Vehicles sold after April 2023 have been certified only up to E20. With lower-ethanol-blend petrol withdrawn from nearly one lakh fuel stations, consumers have been left with no alternative," he said.

Assuming a 10% mileage loss at ₹100 a litre, he said the hidden loss to consumers would amount to around ₹62,000 crore, based on India's annual fuel consumption of 6,200 crore litres.

The Minister claimed that, after factoring in damage and repair costs due to higher blends, the loss would be around ₹1 lakh crore, but did not elaborate on how he arrived at this figure.

Mr. Arshad demanded that the Union government penalise OMCs for "over-blending" even as the Karnataka government would continue to conduct these tests and release their findings. "Every fuel station in the country should be mandated to display the ethanol blend percentage, allowing consumers to choose between the range of blends available," he said.

‘Sustaining independent journalism a major challenge’

Journalists are working in an environment where having an independent opinion is viewed as an issue, says Kanimozhi at anniversary fete of The Hindu Office and National Press Employees’ Union

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



(From left) L.V. Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd.; Rohit Ramesh, Narayan Lakshman, and Nalini Krishnan, Directors, THGPPL; Ramesh Rangarajan, Chairman, Kasturi and Sons Ltd.; N. Murali, Chairman, THGPPL; M. Kamalanathan, Union General Secretary; Kanimozhi, MP; N. Ravi, Vijaya Arun, and K. Venugopal, Directors, THGPPL, at the 70th anniversary celebrations of The Hindu Office and National Press Employees’ Union in Chennai on Friday. V. UMESH KUMAR

Sustaining independent journalism has become a major challenge, with newspapers across the world facing mounting economic pressures and growing restrictions on the expression of independent opinions, MP Kanimozhi Karunanidhi said in Chennai on Friday.

Speaking at the 70th anniversary celebrations of The Hindu Office and National Press Employees’ Union, she said journalists were now working in an environment where having an independent opinion was viewed as an issue. Referring to the challenges confronting the newspaper industry, she said running a newspaper while upholding its journalistic values had become a major challenge in the present, across the world.

At a time when it was believed that journalists should not have opinions and rather agree with everything, *The Hindu* Group stood out as an organisation that had a distinct point of view, she said.

Fond memories

Recalling her association with the organisation, Ms. Kanimozhi said every visit to the office brought back fond memories of her time working there. She described the workplace as an example of how employees should be treated. She appreciated The Hindu Group Publishing Pvt. Ltd. (THGPPL) for accepting the Union demands.

Pointing to the dramatic transformation of the newspaper industry over the years, THGPPL’s Chairman N. Murali said declining print advertising revenues and growing competition from digital platforms posed significant challenges to traditional media organisations. “Today, it is difficult to define what constitutes news media and what does not,” he observed, pointing to the rapid expansion of social media and digital news platforms. However, proliferation of fake news had also reinforced readers’ trust in established publications.

He said newspapers such as *The Hindu* could not afford to stay away from digital platforms, although the revenue generated through them remained a small fraction of print revenue. While it was difficult to predict how the newspaper industry would evolve in the coming years, he said there would be a place for credible publications such as *The Hindu* and expressed confidence in the institution’s ability to navigate the challenges posed by the changing media landscape with the support of employees and union.

He appreciated L.V. Navaneeth, Chief Executive Officer, THGPPL, and Editor Suresh Nambath for their efforts to sustain the newspaper and navigate the challenges.

Mr. Navaneeth said only a few organisations had managed to survive for 150 years while continuing to uphold their founding principles. Acknowledging that the organisation was facing a period of uncertainty, he said the near future could be more challenging. The collective responsibility was to safeguard the institution’s future for at least another 25 years, taking it towards its 175th anniversary.

General Secretary M. Kamalanathan recalled various achievements of the Union since its inception.

Ramesh Rangarajan, Chairman, Kasturi and Sons Limited; THGPPL Directors N. Ravi, K. Venugopal, Vijaya Arun, Rohit Ramesh, Nalini Krishnan and Narayan Lakshman, and THGPPL Vice-President-Human Resources, R. Subramanian, took part in the event.

SC issues contempt notice to Keralam Congress unit over post against CJI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Noting that judicial restraint is not an institutional weakness, the Supreme Court on Friday sought responses from Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) office-bearers on a plea to initiate contempt proceedings against them for a post against Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

The now-deleted post from the X account of the Indian National Congress Keralam unit had stated, “Dear Surya Kant, if law and order is not your domain, resign now. We will find your replacement who can handle it”.

KPCC president Sunny Joseph had apologised for the post, saying it was not authorised by the organisation.

> Judgments are always open to criticism, however severe. But freedom of expression cannot become a shield of intimidation or interference with the administration of justice
>
> **SUPREME COURT**



Justice Aravind Kumar, heading the Bench, asked if the apology rendered had indeed been heartfelt or just for the sake of form. “The independence of the judiciary is not a matter of political convenience. It is a Constitutional guarantee owed to the people of the Republic. Judgments are always open to criticism, however severe. But freedom of expression cannot become a shield of intimidation or interference with the administration of justice,” the Court remarked.

Issuing notice, the court said the office-bearers of KPCC must show cause why the Supreme Court need not exercise its power to “punish for contempt of itself”.

The court indicated that it would appoint an *amicus curiae* and seek the assistance of the Attorney General of India in the case.

Judicial remand of former T.N. Minister extended

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A special court in Chennai on Friday extended the remand of former School Education Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi in an alleged bribery case relating to the grant of approvals for private schools till November 18.

The Central Crime Branch (CCB) police had arrested Mr. Anbil Mahesh on October 26, following which the special court for cases under the Prevention of Corruption Act remanded him in judicial custody until November 6. He subsequently moved the court seeking bail.

On Friday, Mr. Anbil Mahesh was produced before Special Judge L.S. Sathyamurthy through a video conferencing facility. The judge ordered the extension of remand till November 18.

Earlier, senior counsel Abudukumar Rajarathinam had argued that his client had fully cooperated with the CCB police over three days of custodial interrogation. He said the CCB had registered the case despite the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) being the designated agency to investigate corruption cases, creating confusion over jurisdiction. Mr. Rajarathinam questioned the changing estimates of the bribes allegedly collected by Mr. Anbil Mahesh, stating that the amount had initially been pegged at ₹100 crore and then increased.

Bengaluru man held for killing wife, six of her family members

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a murder spree in Bengaluru, Karnataka, a 52-year-old man allegedly killed his wife and six members of her family, including a seven-year-old boy, and disposed of the bodies at multiple locations on the city’s outskirts and elsewhere in the State over a span of 18 days, police sources said. An 11-year-old boy, who is also a relative of the accused, has been rescued. The accused was allegedly assisted by his 17-year-old daughter.

The prime accused, identified as Indushekar, a cab driver and YouTuber who also ran a monthly tabloid, has been arrested by the Rajajinagar police. The murders are believed to have been committed between October 16 and 31, while the last two bodies were reportedly disposed of on November 1 and 2.

A preliminary police investigation revealed that the accusedinvited the relatives to his house on the pretext of a dinner. “After dinner, when the relatives fell asleep, the accused used a grinding stone to kill the victims,” a source said.

INBRIEF



Bus services for pilgrims to connect Pampa and airports

Sabarimala pilgrims will soon be able to travel from airports to Pampa, with the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation planning air-conditioned bus services from Thiruvananthapuram and Cochin international airports. According to officials, the service – which includes return travel – from the Thiruvananthapuram airport will depart for Pampa at 9.30 p.m. From the Cochin airport, the service to Pampa will depart at 8.30 p.m. The initiative is aimed at improving travel facilities during the Mandala-Makaravilakku season.

Two more bodies of fishermen from T.N. wash ashore in A.P.

Bodies of two more fishermen washed ashore in Andhra Pradesh on Friday, a day after five bodies were traced after a boat carrying nine fishermen from Tamil Nadu capsized off Kothapatnam beach near Ongole, due to Cyclone Murasu. A team of scuba diving experts have also come from Visakhapatnam, along with local Marine Police personnel from Chennai, to inspect the capsized boat. According to Indian Coast Guard, the two bodies were found near Vajjireddypalem and Singarayakonda villages of Prakasam district.

Police bust milk adulteration racket in Telangana, one held

A 43-year-old milk businessman was apprehended by the Future City Police for allegedly adulterating milk with hydrogen peroxide and milk powder at a unit in Pocharam village in Ibrahimpatnam mandal, Telangana, on Friday. The accused, Ande Srishailam, a resident of Pocharam, allegedly mixed hydrogen peroxide and Dholpur milk powder with milk before supplying it to customers in Hyderabad.

HC quashes cruelty case against ‘7th’ husband

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Observing that a woman had allegedly entered into nine marriages and had initiated criminal cases against all of her husbands to extort money from them soon after marriage, the High Court of Karnataka quashed a dowry harassment and cruelty case filed against her “seventh” husband.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna passed the order while allowing a petition filed by Hussain, 49, challenging the registration of a case against him under multiple sections of Indian Penal Code.

The court said multiple marriages do not imply criminality, and the allegations lacked specific facts.

Pinarayi Vijayan’s personal security cover downgraded

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Police has downgraded Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan’s personal security from Z+ to Y category.

The decision was made by the security review coordination committee that also reassessed the security arrangements for the protection of other VIPs, including politicians and judicial officers.

Mr. Vijayan will have a pilot vehicle instead of a convoy while travelling. His security details will also include two personal security guards (PSG).

The revised security classifications were issued to Inspector Generals, Deputy Inspectors Generals and District Police Chiefs a few days ago.

The review was undertaken to assess the existing threat levels of various leaders, official sources said.


Pinarayi Vijayan

Highest category

The Governor and Chief Minister have been assigned the highest security category of Z+, while State Ministers, Speaker and Deputy Speaker will receive Y category security with escort.

Among senior politicians, former Chief Minister A.K. Antony will receive Z category security.

Union Home Minister of State for Petroleum and Tourism Suresh Gopi, Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] general secretary M.A. Baby and CPI(M) leader P. Jayarajan have been allotted a security category of Y. CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan will receive X category security.

The police have also scaled down or withdrawn security provided earlier to various leaders.

Hindu Aikya Vedi leader Valsan Thillankeri, who previously had two PSGs, will only have one as per the revised security arrangements. Besides, the security of BJP State general secretary M.T. Ramesh has been withdrawn.

Abuse of law: court quashes POCSO Act case filed by mother

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Observing that children’s innocence must not become parents’ battleground for vengeance, the High Court of Karnataka has quashed a criminal case registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act against a man and his family members by his wife, alleging sexual assault on their three-year-old daughter.

“A child cannot be reduced to a weapon in the armoury of an estranged spouse. The innocence of childhood cannot be made the currency with which matrimonial scores are settled. Equally, the protection of a child cannot be sacrificed at the altar of a parent’s claim of false implication,” the court said.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna passed the order while allowing a petition filed by a 35-year-old man, his father, mother and brother, challenging the criminal case registered against them by his 33-year-old wife.

Matrimonial dispute

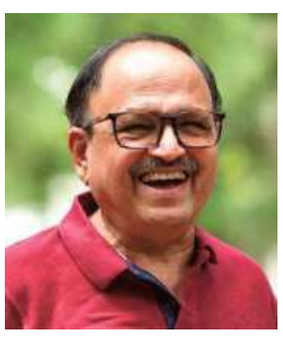
The court noted that the case stemmed from a matrimonial dispute dating back to 2024.

The court granted liberty to the child’s father and his family members to initiate proceedings against the child’s mother, if they were so advised, under Section 22 of the POCSO Act, which safeguards persons against false complaints or information.

K.V. Narayana, noted Kannada critic and linguist, passes away

K.V. Aditya Bharadwaj
BENGALURU

Noted Kannada linguist and critic K.V. Narayana, 78, passed away at his residence in Bengaluru, Karnataka, on Friday. He is survived by his wife, noted writer H.S. Shrimati, and two children. He is reported to have died in his sleep.


K.V. Narayana

A 2024 Sahitya Akademi awardee for his groundbreaking work *Nudigala Alivu*, Prof. Narayana was a popular teacher. The Kannada community has developed its own philosophy and wisdom and has much to give the world, he argued.

Central panel reviews Keralam tourist projects aboard a moving houseboat

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Parliamentary Public Accounts Committee (PAC), chaired by senior Congress leader K.C. Venugopal, on Friday held what he described as the first meeting of its kind aboard a houseboat in the backwaters of Alappuzha, reviewing tourism development initiatives and examining the implementation of the Centre’s Swadesh Darshan scheme and the Sports Authority of India (SAI) Golf Club project in Keralam.


Backwater briefing: The PAC meeting under way on a houseboat travelling from Kumarakom to Alappuzha. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Mr. Venugopal said the committee, along with representatives of the Union Tourism Ministry, the SAI, and the Keralam Government, discussed ways to strengthen tourism infrastructure.

“Tourism is an integral part of Keralam’s economy, and our beautiful State sees lakhs of domestic and international tourists throughout the year. Our endeavour is to ensure the infrastructure is at par with global standards, and also to explore new destinations and opportunities for tourism development,” he said.

According to sources, PAC members were critical of the implementation of the Swadesh Darshan scheme, a centrally funded programme launched in 2014-15.

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U.S. body raises concern over attacks on gurdwaras

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

The United States Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF) on Friday issued a statement expressing concerns over what it referred to as a series of "vigilante attacks" on gurdwaras in India.

"...The United States should link security assistance to the Indian government's response to violence that stops people from exercising [their freedom of religious beliefs]," USCIRF Commissioner David Anderson said. The remarks were followed by another from Commissioner Joe Grogan, calling for the U.S. to take up the cases with the Indian government. While neither elaborated on details of the case, they are believed to be referring to attacks on two gurdwaras in Ludhiana.

However, the Punjab Police that investigated the cases, which involved gunfire attacks outside the places of worship, had concluded that at least one attack was carried out by gurdwara personnel, and had ruled out any religious angle to the attacks.

Gauhati HC quashes detention of Assam activist under NSA

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI


Pranab Doley

The Gauhati High Court on Friday quashed the detention of land rights activist Pranab Doley under the National Security Act (NSA), for protesting a luxury hotel project near Kaziranga National Park. The order paved the way for the 40-year-old's release after 118 days in custody.

The court declared Mr. Doley's preventive detention illegal, observing that the grounds cited by the authorities lacked the required proximity.

He was released from the Golaghat Jail in the evening.

Mr. Doley, convenor of the Greater Kaziranga Land and Human Rights Protection Committee, was arrested on July 12, days after participating in a protest against the luxury hotel project at Ingle Pathar, a village on the periphery of the one-horned rhino's habitat.

According to the police, he trespassed into the site of a Tea Tribes Museum and an adjoining hotel project during the protest, carrying lethal weapons.

A court in Golaghat in eastern Assam granted him bail on July 29, and the State government invoked the NSA against him on July 30.

It alleged that Mr. Doley was involved in suspicious foreign transactions from doubtful sources, in violation of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act. The NSA allows preventive detention without trial for up to 12 months, subject to statutory safeguards.

Various indigenous communities opposed to the luxury hotel project protested Mr. Doley's arrest and subsequent detention under the NSA.

The communities have opposed the project for four years, citing concerns about loss of land and livelihoods.

Union govt. mandates weekly disclosure of rice and paddy stocks

New norms to prevent hoarding and black marketing will remain in force till Jan. 31; govt. lets 5 southern States impose stock limits as prices climb

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI


To improve availability, the Centre is allocating extra rice stocks to NAFED, NCCF and Kendriya Bhandar for sale as Bharat Rice. V. RAJU

With rice prices rising due to a deficient and uneven monsoon, the Centre on Friday directed traders, retailers, wholesalers, processors and millers across the country to declare their rice and paddy stocks.

Under a November 6 order, stocks under six categories must be declared – Basmati rice, non-Basmati premium rice, non-Basmati rice, parboiled rice, broken rice and paddy. Every unit holding stocks will have to update details on the Food Stock Portal (foodstock.dfpd.gov.in) every Friday, the Food Ministry said in a statement.

Units that are not registered on the portal or that violate stock limits will face action under Sections 6 and 7 of the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.

In a separate letter, the Centre has given its consent to Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana to impose stock limits on paddy and rice through control orders.

The limits will remain in force till January 31, 2027. The Centre and States will monitor implementation to ensure adequate availability, and prevent hoarding and black marketing, an official statement said.

To improve availability, the Centre is allocating additional rice stocks to NAFED, NCCF and Kendriya Bhandar for sale as Bharat Rice, and has asked them to explore distribution channels, especially in the southern States.

The Centre has also doubled the target for rice sales through e-auction under the Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic) for 2026-27 from 25 lakh tonnes to 50 lakh tonnes. Around 25 lakh tonnes had been sold to private parties by October 31, compared to 11 lakh tonnes in the same period of last year.

Court seeks response from NewsClick, its editor on ED petition

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Prabir Purkayastha

The Supreme Court on Friday sought responses from news portal NewsClick and its editor-in-chief, Prabir Purkayastha, on a plea by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) against a Delhi High Court order that quashed a money-laundering case registered for alleged violations of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) rules. A Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana issued the notice to the portal and Mr. Purkayastha, and sought their responses within four weeks.

At the outset, the counsel appearing for the ED sought four weeks' time, as Additional Solicitor General S.V. Raju, representing the agency, was not available. Justice Bagchi initially said that the appeal did not inspire confidence.

'Abuse of process of law'

The ED counsel further submitted that the Delhi Police was also in the process of challenging the quashing of the FIR related to the predicate offence and sought a four-week adjournment.

On May 29, the Delhi High Court had said the continuation of an FIR registered by the Delhi Police's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) was "nothing but a gross abuse of the process of law", and once the FIR under the predicate offence was quashed, the ED's Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) in the matter was also liable to be closed.

The EOW's 2020 FIR alleged that PPK NewsClick Studio Pvt. Ltd., the parent company of NewsClick, received ₹9.59 crore FDI from Worldwide Media Holdings LLC, United States, in the financial year 2018-19, in violation of the foreign investment law.

OBC creamy layer verdict will not alter past allocations, says top court

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

> No direction was issued for the retrospective reopening of concluded selections, appointments or service allocations so as to affect the rights of persons who were not parties to the proceedings
> SUPREME COURT



The Supreme Court on Friday clarified that its March 11, 2026 judgment, upholding a 1993 Office Memorandum that excluded parental salary and agricultural income from the income/wealth test for determining OBC non-creamy layer status, did not call for a sweeping revision of service allocations or seniority across successive recruitment years.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and R. Mahadevan, in its order, said the Union government, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, had erred in assuming that a "retrospective implementation of the March 11 judgment would have far-reaching consequences for recruitment, service and cadre allocation, seniority and admissions to Higher Educational Institutions".

In a series of applications, the Centre had expressed apprehensions that a retrospective application of the court's verdict on the assessment of creamy-layer status would unsettle the completed selection process and prejudice candidates. Mr. Mehta had taken the case of the Civil Service Examination (CSE) 2025, of which the results had been announced five days prior to the judgment on March 6.

The government had argued the "potential impact" of the judgment on more than 6.69 lakh reserved vacancies, including 3.7 lakh OBC vacancies, filled over the preceding 10 years across various government departments and public institutions, as well as the consequential effects on seniority, pay, promotional prospects and the Foundation Course for CSE-2025 candidates.

Addressing these apprehensions, the court made it clear that the judgment "cannot be construed as directing a general revision of service allocations or seniority across successive recruitment years, nor does it confer individual relief upon persons who were not parties to the original proceedings".

The court clarified that although the result of the Civil Service Examination 2025 was declared on March 6, services had still not been allocated to the successful candidates. It said that since the process of allocation was pending, there would be no reasonable justification to defer the implementation of the March 11 judgment. It said the creamy layer principle, as interpreted in the judgment, would govern the allocation of services of OBC candidates selected through the Civil Service Examination 2025.

Justice Mahadevan clarified that the March 11 judgment had determined only the rights of the parties (candidates) who approached the Supreme Court.

The order said the Centre was at liberty to formulate policy concerning reservation and the creamy layer in accordance with the Constitution.

Political speculation rife after Praful Patel visits Sharad Pawar in hospital

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI


Talk of the town: Praful Patel interacts with Sharad Pawar at Breach Candy Hospital in Mumbai. PTI

A viral video showing Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar (NCP-SP) leader Sharad Pawar in conversation with Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader Praful Patel has led to political speculation in Maharashtra. Mr. Pawar is currently undergoing treatment at a Mumbai hospital and is likely to be discharged on November 7.

The meeting comes amid a growing rift within the NCP. Sources told *The Hindu* that Mr. Patel reportedly appraised Mr. Pawar of the internal differences within his party and other developments, including a meeting with Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the two core committee meetings, and the discussions therein.

After the visit, Mr. Patel said it was a courtesy call to enquire about the health of the senior Pawar. "We discussed about several issues, including the political situation in the country and in the State," he said.

Meanwhile, NCP State president Sunil Tatkare, in a complete U-turn from his earlier stand, told reporters on Friday that both the NCPs would have been reunited now had Ajit Pawar (Sharad Pawar's nephew and former NCP chief) been alive. "The discussion about reunification was going on when *Dada* [Ajit Pawar] was alive. He had told me about it. But now, the conditions are different. There is no such discussion anymore," he said. He had earlier said that after the younger Pawar's sudden demise that he was not aware of any merger discussions.

After the speculations about the meeting, Maha Vikas Aghadi (the State's Opposition bloc) leaders said that Mr. Pawar would continue to stay with the INDIA bloc.

Shiv Sena UBT leader Sanjay Raut said Mr. Pawar had led progressive politics in the country, and would continue to do so. "He will stay with us," Mr. Raut asserted. NCP-SP MLA Rohit Pawar claimed the merger speculation was being planted by disgruntled elements within the NCP to further their vested interests. He denied any such possibility.

'Keen to merge'

Meanwhile, NCP sources told *The Hindu* that a section of the party's leadership wanted the merger to happen. "But there is no formal proposal about it," a party leader said on condition of anonymity.

Meanwhile, a senior leader of Mahayuti said there was a possibility the speculations were being spread to disturb NCP leader and Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar.

Jharkhand HC quashes State move to cancel exam

Amit Bhelari
PATNA


A CID report and protests by candidates made the govt. cancel the exam on August 17.

The Jharkhand High Court on Friday quashed a State government decision to cancel the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) exam.

Justice Deepak Roshan has also ordered the reinstatement of candidates selected under advertisement number 10/2023, directing that their service be treated as continuous, without any interruption.

A Criminal Investigation Department (CID) report and widespread protests by candidates led the State government to cancel the examination process and any appointments made through it on August 17, 2026.

The decision was made public through a notification on August 18, 2026. On the same day, the Hemant Soren Cabinet decided to cancel 21 other examinations.

Additionally, six other examinations were postponed. The investigation into these examinations was handed over to the CID, with another 17 examinations also to be investigated by the investigative body.

"It is not impossible to identify the suspect and guilty candidates in this matter. Therefore, instead of cancelling the entire examination and the appointments made on its basis, those involved in the irregularities can be identified through an investigation," the court observed.

The court also pointed out that the State government failed to present any concrete evidence proving that the selection process was marred by systematic irregularities.

In response to advocate Amritansh Vats' argument that the decision was contrary to earlier orders passed by the High Court and Supreme Court, the court noted that the appointments were subject to the final outcome of pending criminal proceedings.

Therefore, the decision to cancel the recruitment process before the investigation concluded was not justified, the court ruled.

SC refuses to suspend jail term of Tarun Tejpal in rape case

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

SC agreed to hear his appeal challenging the HC's verdict overturning his acquittal by a trial court in Goa

The Supreme Court on Friday declined to suspend the 10-year prison sentence imposed on journalist Tarun Tejpal by the Goa Bench of the Bombay High Court in a 2013 rape case.

The court, however, agreed to hear his appeal challenging the High Court's August verdict overturning his acquittal by a trial court in Goa.

A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and P.B. Varale held that a *prima facie* examination of the evidence, including witness testimonies and messages placed on record, did not warrant suspension of the sentence. "...with regard to the prosecution witnesses and the material produced and the messages on record, we do not find it a fit ground to grant suspension of sentence," the Bench observed.

The Bench, however, granted leave to appeal in both Mr. Tejpal's petition challenging his conviction and the Goa government's appeal seeking enhancement of his sentence.

During the hearing, senior advocates Kapil Sibal and Siddharth Agarwal, appearing for Mr. Tejpal, sought to discredit the complainant's account of the alleged sexual assault, contending that it was contradicted by CCTV footage and technical evidence.

Rahul and Minister spar over 'rights theft using SIR'

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI


Rahul Gandhi

Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Friday flagged Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh's remarks that voter IDs would replace Aadhaar for identifying beneficiaries of social welfare programmes, saying, "This isn't just vote theft, it's rights theft." The Minister hit back, accusing the Congress leader of "distorting facts" and asserting that the government remains committed to ensuring benefits reach the right people.

Mr. Gandhi, in a post on X, said, "The conspiracy runs very deep; take your time to understand it. Under the guise of special intensive revision (SIR), millions of names are being struck off voter lists. If not stopped, even more will be removed. Whose names are being targeted the most? Those who are furious with the BJP."

Voter lists are in the hands of "Modi government employee Gyanesh Kumar," whose collusion with the BJP in vote theft "we've caught red-handed," he said. He alleged that the government is preparing an electoral roll to keep the BJP in power and that this list will decide who gets access to welfare schemes.

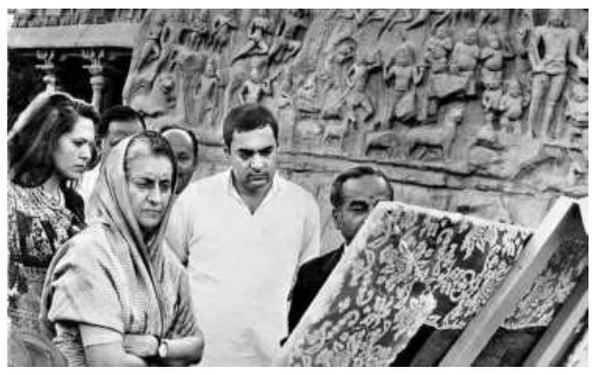
Meanwhile, the Minister called Mr. Gandhi a "restless soul" and said that the Congress leader has "mastered the art of distorting facts," twisting them according to his convenience and to suit his narrative. The Minister said that voter ID and biometric authentication, along with the Aadhaar card, will be used to verify beneficiaries of social welfare schemes.

However, he did not make this distinction when he spoke on Friday at the "People's Plan Campaign (PPC) 2026-27" organised by his Ministry in New Delhi, nor when he reiterated his remarks on Tuesday in Sikkim.

He also accused Mr. Gandhi of linking everything to SIR. "The government is committed to ensuring that benefits reach genuine beneficiaries directly, leaving no scope for middlemen to misuse the system," he said.

PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES


Sonia Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi during their wedding in 1968.


The family on a visit to Mamallapuram, Tamil Nadu, in 1976.


A prayer meeting at the Sanjay Gandhi Samadhi in 1981.


At the swearing-in ceremony of Rajiv Gandhi in 1984.

‘Great damage done to the fabric of India by BJP’

‘When I arrived in India as a young bride, I knew nothing about India. All that I am and know today, I learnt from them (Rajiv and Indira Gandhi). Their courage, their empathy, their commitment to a secular and democratic India and most of all, the pull of duty that was greater than any other for both of them was something that inspired me and held me steadfast during times of difficulty and doubt.’

In this wide-ranging interview to ***The Hindu*** *on her soon-to-be-launched book,* ***Belonging: A Journey of Love****, published by HarperCollins India, Sonia Gandhi responds in writing to a number of questions, personal, historical, and political, raised by* **N. Ram.** *The subjects covered include how she came to write her story about belonging; the values she grew up with and came to learn and cherish in India; what she learnt from Rajiv Gandhi and Indira Gandhi and how they shaped her life and outlook; the “great damage … done to the fabric of our country, our democracy and our institutions” by the BJP-RSS dispensation; how she viewed, and now looks back on, the Emergency of 1975-1977; the major political decisions she made to accept the office of Congress President in 1998 and to continue in it, after a challenge by some colleagues, in 1999, and in 2004 to decline the offer to become Prime Minister; the current political situation and the prospects of the Congress and its coalition partners; and the change of publisher in India just weeks before the book’s launch.*

‘Others have spent decades telling my “story”,’ you posted on X the other day, ‘now it’s my turn.’ My AI-assisted bibliographical search suggests there are at least 75 books, including several biographies, that attempt or purport to tell your story in substantial measure. Your post hints that you were amused rather than irritated or angry about others presuming to tell your story. Am I right? And did you read those books, or at least some of them, written by biographers and others who spent decades telling your ‘story’?

I had no idea there were so many! But I have never felt like reading books about myself. A long time ago Rajiv and I realised that there was no point in trying to keep up with all that had been written about us. But, as I say in the book, there came a time when I felt that I should tell my own story.

In the Prologue to *Belonging*, you give us an insight into how you came to write your story, ‘perhaps…a story worth sharing,’ as you put it somewhat self-deprecatingly. Was it the ‘chorus’, which was on your case for years, or something within you, or both that eventually pushed you over the line to give us this intimate and unusually candid story? And may I ask how long it took you to write the book, breaks and all?

It’s been such a long time that I’ve lost track, but it has certainly been more than a decade since I first wrote a bit. I only started writing in earnest about five years ago. It wasn’t an uninterrupted process. There were times when words and thoughts flowed, others when nothing would come out, and I would throw my hands up in frustration.

3. You describe *Belonging* as a personal memoir, with politics providing the background or ‘a kind of framework’. But it’s really a love story at its heart and that’s how I read it. The story of an extraordinary, instantly formed magnetic bond of love between Rajiv and Sonia, which gradually grew into something much larger, drawing you into the highest circles of power, then reluctantly into public life and politics, and eventually making you one of the country’s foremost political leaders. Stranger than fiction, isn’t it?

Yes! That’s one reason I had no desire to talk about it for so long. But it is not only a love story between the two of us, it’s also the story of how I grew to love Rajiv’s family and the country to which they belonged, and then I too came to belong in it. And of how this love brought me into public life, when I saw the purpose of all the sacrifices they had made being threatened, and the party was weakening. I felt I had to do something.

The writer R.K. Narayan once observed that, despite the passage of time and physical ageing, ‘the chap inside is the same,’ capturing the enduring sense of self. You grew up in a small town in Italy, in a family and social environment far removed from the world that you would eventually inhabit and make your own. Looking back over more than six decades in India, how much of that young Italian woman survives in the person you are today?

The values that I learnt growing up survive. I have tried my best to be true to them: loyalty to family and friends, sincerity and feeling for others, the idea of being dutiful and responsible. I think I can say that in these I am the same person Rajiv met sixty years ago. But I used to smile and laugh a lot more then!

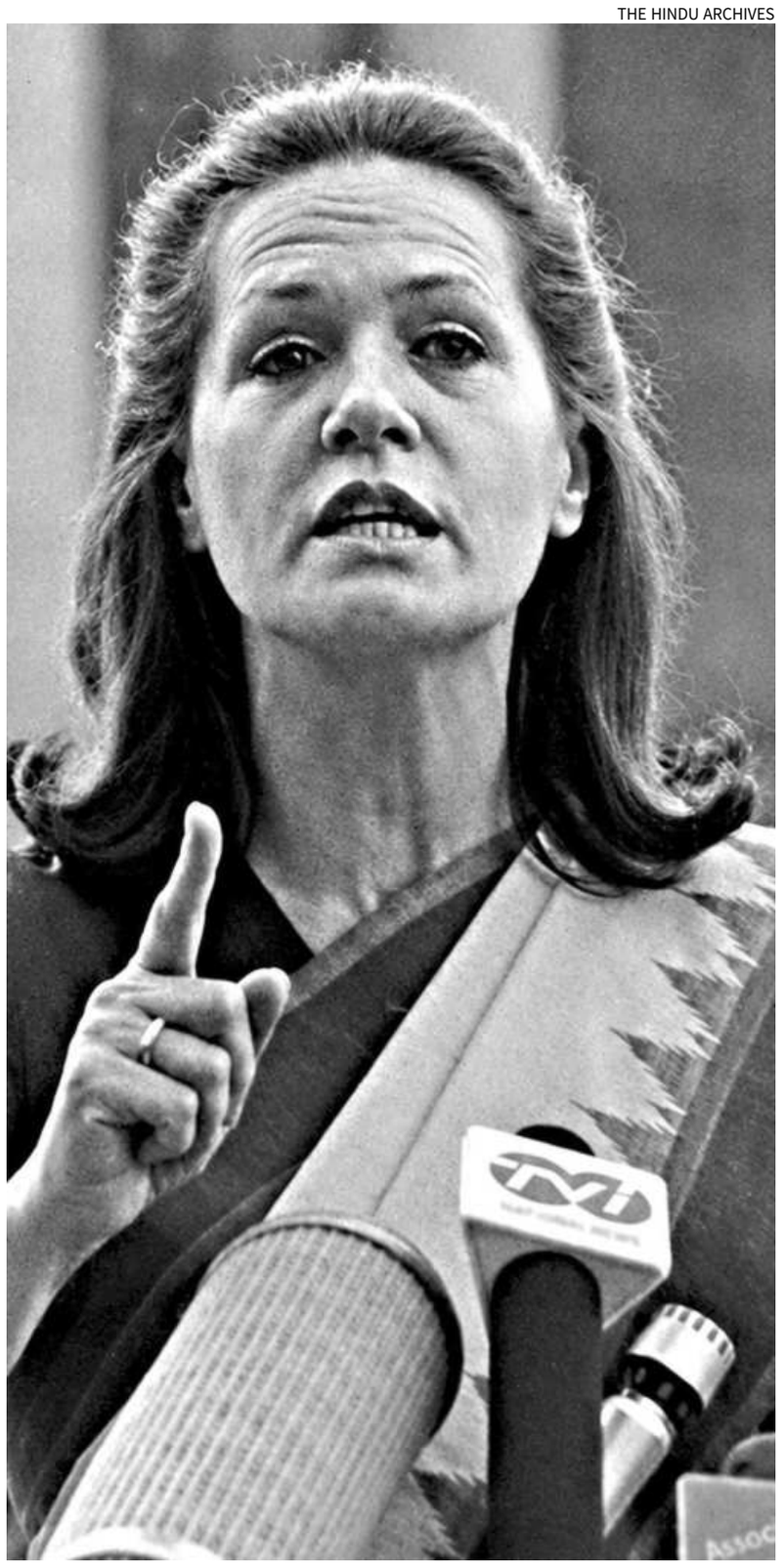
Rajiv Gandhi, the love of your life, and Indira Gandhi, with whom you shared an exceptionally close bond, are central figures in your story. Looking back, what do you see as their defining qualities and the ways in which each shaped your life and outlook?

When I arrived in India as a young bride, I knew nothing about India. All that I am and know today, I learnt from them. Their courage, their empathy, their commitment to a secular and democratic India and most of all, the pull of duty that was greater than any other for both of them was something that inspired me and held me steadfast during times of difficulty and doubt.

You write that Sanjay Gandhi’s name had become synonymous with the Emergency, and that Rajiv used to report complaints or feedback he had heard to his mother, but there was never any response from her. Do you think the so-called excesses of the Emergency could have been avoided had Indira Gandhi listened to her elder son and to others who were honest with her about what they had heard or experienced or observed?

It was not only Sanjay, though in the public mind he is often seen as synonymous with the Emergency. There was a lot of pressure from some of her senior colleagues, and I think there were very few people around her like Rajiv who had a different point of view. I think eventually my mother-in-law began to understand the situation through her own wisdom and took actions to remedy it.

The Emergency I lived through and opposed was, indisputably, a dark chapter in the history of independent India. Fortunately, it was short-lived for a complexity of reasons. You write interestingly about the Emergency in the book and it is clear that you disapprove, like Rajiv did, of many things that happened at that time. Would it not be correct to recognise it as an anti-democratic and authoritarian chapter rather than as a period of over-centralised governance marred by ‘excesses’?


THE HINDU ARCHIVES

It was only after the Emergency that I came to know the true gravity of what had been happening. Yes, democratic rights had been curtailed and there was a suspension of habeas corpus, but it was done constitutionally. Yet, when I take myself back to that period and try and see it from Mrs. Gandhi’s point of view, I see her struggling to cope with the rapidly deteriorating prevailing circumstances: violent protests, government offices and public transport set on fire, widespread organised unrest and even a call for the bureaucracy and armed forces to disobey orders. Hindsight allows us to put things better in perspective. Let’s not forget that it was Mrs. Gandhi herself who came to recognise what was happening and called for the March 1977 election. And you know very well that she herself later publicly expressed regret and apologised for excesses during the Emergency.

Some of the most interesting and insightful passages in your book concern the RSS, the BJP, and the Sangh Parivar, and the dangers they pose to India’s society and polity, particularly to the constitutional values of democracy, secularism, and fraternity. Do you think the Congress Party, historically and in recent times, has differentiated itself clearly, consistently, and effectively from the RSS-led Hindutva forces on these fundamental issues that matter so deeply to you?

But of course! I admit that there have been some within the party who felt we should not be so black and white on the issue of secularism. But that is not the Party view. In our policies and actions, I believe we have been steadfast in standing with the constitutional right of our people to worship and practise their religion and belief without fear.

On Prime Minister Narendra Modi, you write that you and he come from different ideological worlds and have very different ideas of India. Yet you also recognise something of his discomfort with the ruling elite. In a striking passage in the book, you recall feeling ill at ease in Delhi drawing rooms, where political opinions seemed ‘very far removed from the reality of India.’ The suffering and struggle to survive that you had witnessed in your constituency and across the country seemed unimaginable to this privileged group. You also observe that, although Modi’s humble origins may have been exaggerated by his PR team, he “had certainly worked his way to power within the RSS from an underprivileged world.” What political lessons should the Congress draw from this?

It’s true that he comes from a very different ideological world. But there are many ways that people succeed in politics - within the Congress party, take for example Dr. Manmohan Singh and Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge. I don’t think we have much to learn from the RSS.

You record your sense of hurt over Congress leaders Sharad Pawar, P.A. Sangma, and Tariq Anwar raising the issue of your foreign origin and asserting that you could not hold high office in India. ‘I felt tears welling up and walked out of the meeting. I hadn’t entered politics to grab position and power. It was some of these colleagues who had urged me to join politics, and now they were turning on me…It wasn’t the issue of holding office that hurt me; it was that my loyalty to India was being questioned.’ You submitted your resignation as Congress President, but you were persuaded by party leaders to continue. Did this episode steel your resolve not to accept the prime ministership should the opportunity arise?

Of course, I felt hurt. These were my colleagues and they’d had my trust, but then it turned out that I didn’t have theirs. It came as a shock that they still saw me as an outsider. Looking back, I can see they may have had their own reasons. But this was early in my political life, and the idea of prime ministership couldn’t have been further from my mind. Yes, I did resign, but then after some soul-searching I realised that I could not let my personal feelings divert me from my larger purpose. I had to continue.

Chapter Thirty is, arguably, the most interesting chapter politically, and one of the most moving personally. It offers new insights into your decision not to become Prime Minister after the Congress-led victory in 2004, when virtually everyone expected you to take office. Months before the general election, you had told one of your children, “Absolutely not,” when asked whether you would accept the post should the Congress pull off a win. Rahul and Priyanka were strongly opposed, haunted by the assassinations of their grandmother and father and convinced that the office carried exceptional danger. Yet, amid the ‘surreal drama’ of party leaders pressing you to accept, you relented with a ‘*Theek hai*’, only to change your mind. Dr. Manmohan Singh became Prime Minister instead. Do you ever wonder how UPA policies and Congress strategy might have differed had you accepted? I ask because you are widely seen as more of a social democrat than Dr. Singh and most Congress leaders, then and now.

No, not at all. That has never crossed my mind. Our experience was by and large a very positive one. We worked as a team, and our roles were distinct with him leading the government and I leading the party.

You make it clear in the Epilogue that you have no regrets in your personal life over coming to India and making your life here with the family you married into. You also strike a hopeful note when you observe that when you joined the Congress Party and became its President, you discovered that ‘individuals have untapped reserves that come into play when life calls them to perform tasks they had thought unimaginable.’ However, you write that where you struggled with doubts was when you were called upon to make political compromises. ‘I ask myself now,’ you write, ‘did those compromises even serve their objectives? Not always. Even when they seemed to favour the party, I couldn’t rejoice, deep down. They still don’t sit lightly on my conscience.’ What were these compromises? Could you give us a couple of examples?

Let’s be realistic, in politics compromises are at times unavoidable. Sometimes we were faced with difficult political choices, when we were obliged to join hands with some who did not share our political ideology. It never sat easy in my mind. But of one thing I am perfectly clear: we never made any compromises with the BJP and the RSS and we never will.

You rue the end of decency and decorum in parliamentary politics and public life in the last decade and more - ‘a heartlessness that accompanies authoritarian regimes to belittle and torment those who differ from them.’ Do you believe things will change and politics will return to a contest over policies and programmes if the BJP is voted out of power in the 2029 Lok Sabha election?

Over the last twelve years great damage has been done to the fabric of our country, our democracy and our institutions. Even after this government goes it will take time to restore our systems back to health, and great effort from political parties. People are now beginning to be restless and recognising the damage. But I am optimistic and I know that the people of India will welcome a return to proper governance.

The decline of the Congress as India’s dominant party is a fact of political life. Over the past three decades, the Congress has struggled to halt the advances made by the Hindutva forces. There was some revival of fortunes between 2004 and 2014, but critics say that the party has not been able to reverse the declining trend. You write extensively about the Congress in your book. How do you assess its present condition and prospects?

I am not so pessimistic. Consider that the Congress party and other opposition parties have not had a level playing field since this government came to power. Take into account the complete stranglehold they have on all institutions, especially the Election Commission, their control of mainstream media, their money power and their exploitation of religion. Yet, our party is fighting and making progress, in fact, it is the only party that has had the resilience to withstand this onslaught. Our workers and leaders have been extremely courageous. They have faced persecution of all kinds and yet, in every village and every district, congressmen and women are still fighting for the values enshrined in our Constitution. What is more, it has been amply proved in recent months that many elections have been stolen, and people are now more aware of it. The Congress is working with like-minded parties, and our prospects are improving day by day.

It is unusual for a book of such personal and political significance, certain to attract a wide readership in India and abroad, to change publishers just months before its launch. In late August 2026, it emerged that Penguin Random House India would no longer publish *Belonging: A Journey of Love*. In early September, HarperCollins India announced its publication on November 10. The change prompted considerable speculation. One newspaper report suggested disagreements over passages concerning Narendra Modi, the RSS, communal tensions and minorities, and India’s confrontation with China, including Galwan. Penguin said that following disagreements over the manuscript your team decided not to proceed with publication. Is that account correct? Was this a disagreement over the book’s contents, or were larger questions of a writer’s freedom of expression involved?

I would rather not involve myself in these controversies.

INBRIEF



PM Modi greets nation on Dhanteras, wishes good health

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday greeted people on the occasion of *Dhanteras*, the first day of Deepavali festivities, and hoped their lives would always be illuminated with happiness, peace and good health by the divine grace of Lord Dhanvantari. He also urged everyone to make a commitment to better health. "Wishing endless warm greetings to all fellow countrymen on the occasion of *Dhanteras*. May everyone's life always be illuminated with happiness, peace and good health by the divine grace of Lord Dhanvantari. May the eternal lamp of joy and cheer remain ignited in every family" Mr. Modi said in a post on X. PTI

One killed and six injured in a fire at an OIL facility in Assam

One person died and six others were injured in a major fire at an Oil India Limited (OIL) installation in eastern Assam's Dibrugarh district on Friday. The exploration major said in a statement that the fire broke out around 9.05 a.m. at the indirect bath heater, isolated since November 4 for maintenance, in its intermediate tank farm at Tengakhat. "Seven persons of the O&M (Operations and Maintenance) contractor sustained burn injuries in the fire incident. While six persons were rescued and taken for medical treatment, one person succumbed to the injuries at the incident site," the statement read.

SC says curbs on vehicles and construction are 'failed tools'

Court asks Centre if it has scientific solutions to pollution; govt. says CAQM measures not complete failure; urbanisation, festive activities, stubble burning make pollution control uphill task, it says

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Friday termed measures such as banning vehicles and construction to curb air pollution in the national capital as "old, tried and failed tools".

A Bench, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, asked the Union government and the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) if they had any "significant scientific method other than stopping vehicles and stopping construction".

Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, arguing for the CAQM and the Centre, said that it would not be completely true to call such measures a "complete failure". Ms. Bhati said emergency and pre-emptive measures like Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) have at least been able to arrest air pollution at sustainable levels.

"For us, it is either 'severe' and 'very severe'. 'Very poor' is normal. We are already touching 400. Let us not talk about a utopia where the AQI would become 100 or less," Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the three-judge Bench, addressed the CAQM.

> Any vehicle can come to Delhi... You cannot monitor what kind of fuel is being used, what kind of pollution they are generating. What is the overall condition of these vehicles? Is there a mechanism to check? But even if you tell them to go back, the damage would already have been done
>
> **JUSTICE JOYMALYA BAGCHI**
> Supreme Court judge



"But every human activity, particularly in a festive season, will cause pollution. How much can we stop? Delhi invites and attracts talent and search for livelihoods from across the country. There is also a little stubble burning. In many ways, we are only doing management. But human activities have expanded so fast that we are still catching up to it," Ms. Bhati said.

The exchange in open court happened merely hours before the national capital graduated to GRAP-III restrictions with the air quality index rising over 400. The court said the "commodification and commercialisation" of Deepavali by affluent, status-driven people has worsened air pollution. The poorest sections of the population, who cannot afford the splurge, often bear the worst consequences.

The CJI said it was "free for all" on the capital's roads. Even improving the fuel would not change the pollution statistics.

"Any vehicle can come to Delhi... You cannot monitor what kind of fuel is being used, what kind of pollution they are generating; What is the overall condition of these vehicles? Is there a mechanism to check? But even if you tell them to go back, the damage would already have been done," the CJI addressed the government's law officer.

Chief Justice Kant said no orders from the court could possibly clear the thickening smog unless the public decided to mend their ways. Justice V. Mohana suggested awareness campaigns as a desperate measure to reign in the toxic air.

The judge said people need to revert to the "original customs and cultural practices" around Deepavali. "Going back to *diyas* and the simple things in life, that would be ideal," *amicus curiae*, senior advocate Aparajita Singh, agreed.

Senior advocate Sanjiv Sen, who appeared for the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), faced questions about the long trail of vehicles lying idle at Delhi borders. Mr. Sen said the only way that could be prevented during Deepavali would be to ban people from rushing to and fro with gifts.

The court agreed to pass directions, and list the case after the Deepavali vacations.

Cybercriminals have no place in society, says Supreme Court

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



The SC rejects a bail plea and stresses that cyber fraudsters belong behind bars.

The Supreme Court on Friday said cybercriminals do not deserve anything more than being locked up in jail.

"They have no space in society," Chief Justice Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, said orally while rejecting a bail plea by an accused in a cyber-fraud case.

"We are ruthless about cybercriminals. There is no sympathy coming from us. Cybercriminals have no space in society, and jails are only meant for them," the Chief Justice said. The court said even murderers have a chance of being rehabilitated, but not cyber-fraudsters. "You can release murderers. They can be rehabilitated. But not cybercriminals. They should not be anywhere but in jail," he said.

Cyber safeguards

Recently, the same Bench mandated Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) and mechanisms to curb cyber fraud and to facilitate time-bound refunds after hearing the grievances of victims. It also directed law enforcement agencies to initiate criminal action through zero FIRs against cyberfraudsters.

The court had referred to a status report by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) of the Ministry of Home Affairs, which said that complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal against digital arrests had fallen from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,249 in 2025, and stood at 16,377 for the period ending June 30, 2026. It had said the e-Zero FIR mechanism was functional in 19 States, while only 14 States had notified their State Cyber Crime Coordination Centres. The Telecommunications (Radio Equipment Possession Authorisation) Rules, 2025, have been notified, while the Telecommunications (User Identification) Rules, 2025, were at the final stage of notification.

CBSE Class 10, 12 exams to begin on February 16

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) announced on Friday that the 2027 Class 10 and Class 12 Board examinations will begin on February 16. The Class 10 exams will conclude on March 9 and the Class 12 exams on April 9.

"In Class 10, students will appear in 83 subjects and in Class 12, students will appear in 121 subjects. The date sheets are being released 101 days in advance of the commencement of examinations," CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj said. Over 19.8 lakh students in Class 12 and 26.5 lakh students in Class 10 have registered for the 2027 examinations. The full date sheets can be accessed on the CBSE's official website.

(With inputs from PTI)

REACH becomes first Indian civil society group to get Kochon Prize

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Resource group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH), a not-for-profit organisation working to strengthen the tuberculosis (TB) response in India, has been awarded the Kochon Prize 2026, becoming the first civil society, non-profit organisation from India to receive this prestigious global recognition for its contributions to combating TB, a press release said.

Presented by the Kochon Foundation, an independent Korean non-profit foundation, in partnership with the Stop TB Partnership, the Kochon Prize recognises individuals and organisations that have made significant contributions to the fight against TB.

The 2026 Kochon Prize is shared by REACH, the Centre for Health Solutions, Kenya, and the Marshall Islands TB Control Program.



REACH has been honoured for its contributions to fighting tuberculosis. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"Treat the person, not the disease - our journey with TB communities has been just that. We realised early on that overcoming barriers to care means addressing more than clinical needs - it means recognising social, community, family, mental health and situational challenges. That is the essence of integrated care: seeing the whole person, understanding their realities, and doing whatever it takes to ensure that no one is left behind," said Nalini Krishnan, chairperson and co-founder, REACH.

"REACH is a remarkable and rare organisation that has been consistently ahead of the curve in terms of public health action, and particularly in the field of TB. A women-led organisation, they genuinely care about the people they're supporting, beyond the numbers, data and reports to donor. However, they combine this with a robust scientific and technical approach and a shrewd understanding of the public health landscape in the country," said Soumya Swaminathan, chairperson, M. S. Swaminathan Research Foundation and former chief scientist, WHO, who nominated REACH for the award.

"This recognition is testimony to the dedication of the community health workers, TB Nanbans and TB Champions who work alongside us, and to the families who have placed their trust in us. We are deeply grateful to their unwavering commitment and fortitude, " said Ramya Ananthakrishnan, director, REACH.

Congress urges Centre to roll back Agnipath scheme

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday renewed its demand for scrapping the Agnipath scheme, alleging that it had weakened the country's security and left the armed forces facing a shortage of over two lakh soldiers. The party also demanded that Agniveers selected for permanent service be given all benefits of regular soldiers retrospectively, from the date of their recruitment.

The Congress's demands came two days after the Union Cabinet approved changes to the scheme, including a two-year extension for Agniveers completing their initial four-year tenure, and the possibility of permanent recruitment thereafter on meeting the eligibility criteria.

Addressing a press conference, chief of the party's ex-servicemen department, Colonel Rohit Chaudhry (retd) said the scheme was imposed on the armed forces by the Narendra Modi government despite the three Service chiefs having stated that they had not recommended it.



The Congress's demands came two days after the Union Cabinet approved changes to the scheme. M. SATHYAMOORTHY

"This was a scheme that weakened our country's security," he said, adding that the Congress had campaigned against it under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi through its 'Jai Jawan' campaign.

Colonel Chaudhry alleged that the scheme had resulted in a shortage of more than two lakh soldiers and shattered the hopes of 1.5 lakh candidates who had been recruited into the Army and the Air Force but were awaiting their joining orders when the recruitment process was discontinued.

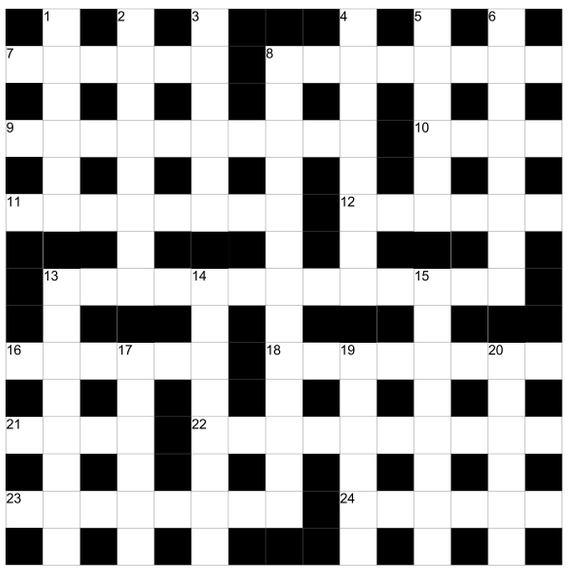
The Congress leader also alleged that more than 40 Agniveers had died by suicide, attributing the deaths to the scheme, discrimination and service conditions.

TH CROSSWORD + 14943

(set by Saral)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



ACROSS

7. Will unwrapped hoarding roughly (6)
8. Extremely nice craftwork on large excellent band (8)
9. Flier skiing casually around fellow leading that woman (10)
10. Press withdrawing some section originally (4)
11. Double dealing in gamble with king on ace against amateur in retreat (8)
12. Colour of stylish work outfit principally (6)
13. Very similar building opposite with a primarily aesthetic natural design (3,4,2,1,3)
16. Cleric from Italy entering book store (6)
18. Perfect small round instrument next to sailor (8)
21. Partly cook ravioli vegetable (4)
22. Exceptional and fantastic rugs in spas (10)
23. Asked enrolled nurse about splitting money (8)
24. At work ordering donut at the end of day (2,4)

DOWN

1. Line cutting two diamonds that produces smoky effect (3,3)
2. Jumper damaging organ during tree climbing (8)
3. Hatred and wickedness killing men (6)
4. Stinger spreading poison finally toxic vapour (8)
5. Joined everyone with papers outside office at last (6)
6. Bill preparing food essentially egg for Arnab, say (3,2,3)
8. Hero sold brand actively without restrictions (2,5,6)
13. Sets bar with layers having one cake regularly (8)
14. Former model bored by old city promotion (8)
15. Friend with fresh ideas for defence (8)
17. Not starting shiatsu, relaxing in interval (6)
19. Follow husband in blue with old wife (6)
20. Rules of European occupying temporary shelters (6)

SUDOKU

				9	1		5	3
	7			3		2		
5			7		2	9		
							3	
		9	2		4	1		
	5							
		5	8		7			1
		2		6			7	
7	6		4	5				

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

Solution to previous puzzle

R	E	S	I	T	S		L	I	V	E	I	T	U	P
A		O		R		D		N		L		R		A
D	R	A	M	A		I	N	T	H	E	P	I	N	K
I		P		M		G		H		G		E		I
S	H	O	W	P	I	E	C	E		A	I	D	E	S
H		P		L		S		F		N				T
	D	E	M	E	N	T	I	A		T	H	E	T	A
S		R				I		M				R		N
T	E	A	S	E		V	O	I	C	E	B	O	X	
E				V		E		L		G		T		D
P	A	S	T	A		T	H	Y	R	O	X	I	N	E
O		A		S		R		W		T		C		T
N	U	L	L	I	P	A	R	A		R	A	I	T	A
I		S		V		C		Y		I		S		I
T	R	A	V	E	S	T	Y		A	P	P	E	A	L

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

2	6	8	9	4	5	1	7	3
7	4	3	1	2	8	9	5	6
1	5	9	3	6	7	8	2	4
5	8	7	6	1	4	3	9	2
9	3	1	5	7	2	6	4	8
4	2	6	8	9	3	7	1	5
8	9	2	4	3	1	5	6	7
3	1	4	7	5	6	2	8	9
6	7	5	2	8	9	4	3	1

FAITH

Deepavali: light up inner self

Scriptures say when one surrenders to Perumal in all humility, He negates all the negative actions of one until that time. Festivals celebrating the fall of asuras and their subsequent liberation illustrate this aspect admirably. Deepavali, the festival of lights celebrating the fall of the Narakasura underscores this perfectly, said Damal S. Ramakrishnan.

Deepavali is a festival of lights, not merely of the exterior landscape, but more importantly of one's inner self. The legend of Narakasura is a well-known one. Born as the son of Bhoo Devi, Narakasura undertook severe penance and was granted the boon that none barring his mother could kill him. He unleashed a series of atrocities. Lord Krishna took on the asura in a fierce bout, but the power of the boon held and Krishna fell faint in the chariot. His Consort Satyabhama took charge of the situation and wounded him mortally. She was none other than Bhoo Devi. In the time between his fall and death, the asura realised his folly and becoming truly repentant for his sins, sought another boon: His death should be celebrated in a grand manner by mankind as a reminder that only virtue will prevail and will be truly rewarded. On this day the goddesses too help one light up one's inner self. Ganga, the purifier of one's sins, flows into all the waterways. It is customary to have oil bath early in the morning of Deepavali and greet one another with the query, "Is Ganga snan over?" as a way of indicating that one should get rid of one's sins. Goddess Lakshmi, the light that shines brightest, is propitiated for not only wealth but also for wisdom and true happiness, in a grand manner in the evening.

Epic failures

The electoral roll cannot be used to determine welfare beneficiaries

Union Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh's statement that voter identity cards, with biometric authentication, will replace Aadhaar as the basis for identifying beneficiaries and making payments under his Ministry's schemes runs contrary to existing laws and regulations. Essentially, the electoral roll, prepared in several States through the flawed Special Intensive Revision (SIR) by the Election Commission of India (ECI), will become the dataset to vet the identities of beneficiaries. This contradicts the Supreme Court's May 27 judgment on the Bihar SIR and its observations while hearing petitions against West Bengal's orders removing people deleted during the SIR from the Public Distribution System and the Annapurna Yojana. The Court held that the ECI may undertake only a "limited enquiry" into citizenship to decide who belongs on the electoral roll, and that "any action taken pursuant thereto is confined to electoral consequences alone". The consequence of deletion from the rolls, it said, is "correspondingly limited" to a person's place on the roll and their right to vote. The Court also called the EPIC "a derivative document, issued on the basis of inclusion in the electoral roll", and held that relying on it to verify that very roll would defeat the exercise. It is ironic that Mr. Singh now wants this "derivative document" to be the determinant of welfare benefits.

Not every citizen is an eligible voter, and tying benefits to the electoral roll is illogical and also cruel. In West Bengal, lakhs were deleted from the rolls, many for dubious "logical discrepancies". In the appeals heard for reinstatement, 93% resulted in the restoration of names by September 2026, pointing to massive pre-election disenfranchisement. The Court has stated that it is yet to adjudicate on the legality of the ECI's "logical discrepancies" method. The SIR was designed by the ECI to restrict enrolment through stringent residency criteria; thus, itinerant voters had to prove their eligibility. The Opposition, civil society and even some of the BJP's allies have objected to this, but the BJP refuses to acknowledge the SIR's flaws. This is partly because it has benefited from disenfranchisement – as in West Bengal. But the Minister's remarks suggest another reason. The BJP-led coalition sees the pruned electoral rolls as a way to limit welfare, especially at a time when growth in tax revenues has slowed because of the Centre's policies. Inordinately delaying the Census, changing the procedure to appoint Election Commissioners, who then run an exercise that disenfranchises millions by design, and now, using the resultant rolls to decide who gets welfare, all cut at the heart of the painstakingly built constitutional welfare state. The sooner the Court decides the petitions against the SIR, and reiterates that its rolls cannot be used to curtail welfare, the better.

Young and fast

As F1's youngest champion, Antonelli can attract a new generation of fans

Andrea Kimi Antonelli etched his name in motorsport history by becoming the youngest driver to win a Formula One World Championship. The 20-year-old has secured his maiden title with four races to spare after finishing third at the Mexico Grand Prix on Sunday. The Italian's feat is remarkable, for he has claimed the crown in his sophomore campaign, becoming only the fifth driver in history to do so in the first or second season. Mercedes signed Antonelli for its junior driver programme when he was just 12. Since then, the Italian's step towards F1 has been meticulously managed. After acing the F4 championships, Antonelli skipped one level to transition to F2. And when the opportunity arose to fill a seat vacated by seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton, Mercedes boss Toto Wolff took a bold gamble by drafting in the youngster. Antonelli's rookie campaign in 2025 was baptism by fire, and he was outclassed by teammate George Russell. For 2026, F1 ushered in drastic changes with new engine and aerodynamic regulations, dramatically altering the dynamics of the cars. Though conventional wisdom suggested that the experienced Russell would be the favourite, the Italian prodigy embraced the challenge astonishingly well. This was best exemplified by how he won five consecutive races starting from the second round of the season.

One of the hardest things in F1 is handling the nerves associated with protecting the lead, especially when it is the driver's first attempt at a Championship bid. Antonelli, though, was incredibly consistent throughout the year, and hardly made any errors. Titles are often decided by how a driver minimises his losses on bad days, and Antonelli showed great temperament in this regard. At the same time, he was ruthless on the track and made decisive overtaking manoeuvres. The defining race was in Monza, Italy, in September where Antonelli charged from 19th on the grid to win his home Grand Prix, finishing ahead of Russell who started second. It was a statement of intent, and strengthened his grip on the trophy. Drivers often raise their games following a world title, more so when success comes early in their career. Considering the giant leap Antonelli made to become F1's first champion to be born in the 21st century, he will undoubtedly attract a new generation of fans. The charm of the sport lies in its iconic driver rivalries such as Ayrton Senna versus Alain Prost, and Michael Schumacher versus Mika Hakkinen. With four-time champion Max Verstappen widely considered the gold standard of the present era, Antonelli could well be the perfect candidate to battle the Dutchman in F1's next great rivalry.

The struggle for justice is indivisible



Brinda Karat

Senior leader of the Communist Party of India (Marxist)

In the district jail in Panna, in Madhya Pradesh, a 24-year-old woman walked into the Superintendent's office, her bright eyes alight as she stretched out her hands to greet us. She is Divya Ahirwar, an elected ward councillor from a Scheduled Caste-reserved seat, who has been in jail since September 27 on a fabricated charge of attempted murder. She has now been granted bail by the High Court of Madhya Pradesh in Jabalpur. Along with Amit Bhatnagar, founder of the Jai Kisan Sangathan, Divya has been at the forefront of a movement seeking justice for thousands of Adivasi and Dalit families facing displacement because of three projects in the State's Panna and Chhatarpur districts. Amit, who undertook a hunger strike lasting several weeks, has also faced arrest.

The three projects are the Majhgaya dam, the Runjh dam and the Ken-Betwa river-linking project. These are distinct projects, with different administrative histories and varying scales of displacement. But they share a common thread: the flagrant violation of the rights of project-affected families. The project sites have become centres of intense repression and brave resistance. The conflict raises fundamental questions about the power equations between the state, the class interests it represents and those against whom that power is exercised.

We fight to save the Constitution. Yet, under this very Constitution, every minute of every day, somewhere in India, the state runs its savage bulldozer over the constitutional rights of citizens simply because they are poor. It crushes lives, livelihoods and the very means of survival. Such is its power that even the sound of its movement is silenced. Dr. B.R. Ambedkar said that the Constitution is only as good or as bad as those responsible for implementing it. A few days spent in these villages reveal the profound truth of his words.

Water projects, displaced lives

Our team from the CPI(M) and the Adivasi Adhikar Rashtriya Manch met hundreds of affected families. The first two projects are medium irrigation projects undertaken by the Madhya Pradesh government and are now nearing completion. Started more than a decade ago, they have left hundreds of affected households, most of them Adivasi, still waiting for fair compensation.

Take Banharikala village, for instance. The backwaters of the Majhgaya dam had already begun flooding homes and fields, submerging standing crops. With no shelter for their livestock, residents were forced to sell their cows and goats at distress prices. The government initially offered some families ₹5 lakh as a "package". Sustained protests eventually forced it, as late as December 2025, to increase the package to ₹12.5 lakh.

Section 38(1) of the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, mandates that, for irrigation projects, "the rehabilitation and resettlement shall be completed six months prior to submergence of the lands acquired".

> From Panna to Delhi, the fight against displacement and disenfranchisement has a common thread – a struggle against state repression and the systematic erosion of a citizen's constitutional rights

These requirements were wilfully disregarded. An incomplete survey resulted in the underestimation of compensation for land, houses and trees. The government refuses to revise the 2018 cut-off date, despite implementation taking place eight years later. Children who were minors then have since become adults, yet are denied their legally mandated separate compensation entitlements as adult members of a household. Scores of families have received nothing. The uncertainty has gripped the village: children have dropped out of school and families are deep in debt. None of this need have happened had the government acted according to the law. The same situation prevails in most villages affected by the Majhgaya and Runjh dams.

Residents have responded with the now well-known *chita andolan*, or funeral pyre movement, in which they lie on funeral pyres, put their heads in nooses or stand waist-deep in water. Their slogan is: "*Nyay do ya maar do* (Give us justice or kill us"). The state has sent battalions of police and cut off electricity. It was here that Divya was dragged and beaten by dozens of police personnel, most of them men. Her clothes were torn, and she was nearly stripped in an attempt to break the movement. But the villagers, many of whom were also beaten and arrested, stand firm.

The third project is the controversial Ken-Betwa river-linking project, which involves constructing a 96.7 metre-high (about 317 feet high) dam near Daudhan village on the Ken. Its stated objective is to bring water to the perennially dry areas of Bundelkhand and neighbouring Uttar Pradesh. However, experts have questioned its viability and environmental consequences.

Judicial scrutiny

In 2019, a central empowered committee constituted by the Supreme Court of India in response to petitions challenging the project delivered a scathing indictment of the official clearances. It questioned whether the Ken had sufficient water, pointed out that 6,000 hectares of the 9,000 hectares required for the project was forest land, including a substantial part of the Panna Tiger Reserve, and warned of the serious environmental consequences of felling an estimated 2.3 million trees. Strangely, the case has remained virtually frozen in the Court since 2019, even as the project moves ahead. The tender was awarded to Hyderabad-based NCC, listed as one of the Bharatiya Janata Party's electoral bond donors. By the time the courts turn their attention to the issue, the project and the resulting submergence could have become a *fait accompli*.

Around 8,000 Adivasi families across 22 villages are directly affected. The Forest Rights Act (FRA) is explicit: under Section 4(5), forest dwellers cannot be evicted until the recognition and verification of their forest rights are complete. Yet, not a single village has had these rights recognised. Community forest rights have been ignored, and gram sabha consent has not been obtained. Four villages lie within the core tiger reserve and are additionally covered by the Wildlife (Protection) Act, which mandates voluntary relocation. There is nothing remotely voluntary about the process being imposed on these communities. Adivasis have lived here for generations. As in the Niyamgiri case, where the Court protected ancestral Adivasi land from being taken over without gram sabha consent, the land here is far more than an economic asset. Sacred groves and places of worship dedicated to village deities and ancestors, integral to Adivasi identity and culture, will be obliterated.

Displacement from three villages has already begun. We visited the so-called resettlement colony, where the promised land-for-land rehabilitation has proved a travesty. Families have been allotted plots of stony land, measuring just 20 feet by 50 feet, without infrastructure, water or even a nearby school. Instead of land titles, families showed us two-inch slips of paper bearing their plot numbers and an illegible signature purportedly that of the Tehsildar, meant to serve as a land title. Within a few months, 10 families have already received notices to move again because the land on which they were resettled is needed for a canal. The scrap of paper issued as a land title has proved worthless.

Across the country, governments are waging an undeclared war on Adivasis. From Simjhali in Odisha and the coal-affected Adivasi villages of the Santhal Parganas to Chhatarpur and Panna, the pattern is the same. Those who have lived in and protected these forests for generations are treated as enemies of the forests, all in the name of development.

The many struggles

On October 2, 2026, the protest at Jantar Mantar in Delhi was against the assault on the right to vote, guaranteed under Article 326 of the Constitution. Here, the protest is against an assault on the right to life itself, guaranteed under Article 21. The two struggles are closely linked. In one instance, selected voters, most of them poor, women, minorities, displaced persons and the homeless, are branded as *ghuspetias* and their right to vote eliminated. In the other, thousands of Adivasis are labelled encroachers and denied their basic constitutional and legal rights. In both cases, what is at stake is citizenship and the struggle against being stripped of the rights of a citizen.

The demands of the numerous struggles taking place across the country are different. But their core is common: defending the Constitution and the struggle to save it from the assault of those in power. The demands for Divya's release, justice for Randal Sequeira and Laxmi Naik, and for the hundreds of Adivasis facing false cases must resonate in the many Jantar Mantars emerging across India. The struggle for justice is indivisible. When this principle is translated into action, it will shake the citadels of class-based power.

Demonetisation and the health costs of cash shortages

Anindya Chakrabarti

Associate Professor of Economics at the Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad

Chirantan Chatterjee

Professor of Economics at U-Sussex and a 2025 Founding Fellow of the Royal Economic Society

Samarth Gupta

Assistant Professor of Economics at the Indian Institute of Management Calcutta

On November 8, 2016, 86% of India's currency by value was demonetised at four hours' notice, ostensibly to curb black money and counterfeit currency and promote digital payments. Nearly 99.3% of the withdrawn notes returned to the banking system, according to the Reserve Bank of India. Research has shown that the exercise caused a temporary contraction in money supply.

Kenya in 2019 and Nigeria in 2022-23 experienced similar cash shortages after currency withdrawals. As digital public infrastructure expands, an important question remains: how do sudden cash shortages affect access to essential goods such as medicines?

Acute versus chronic, a natural lens

This is the focus of forthcoming research by these writers in the *Journal of Economics and Management Strategy*. The All India Organisation of Chemists and Druggists (AIOCD) database was used using monthly sales of every stock keeping unit (SKU) across 805 pharmaceutical firms, 31 regions and 18 illness categories. It is the first product-region-time level dataset used to study demonetisation. Building on sound economic theory of search costs, the writers theorised that drugs for chronic conditions, purchased monthly, compel consumers to find the cheaper options. Drugs for acute conditions such as infections, pain, gastro-intestinal are bought due to unanticipated onset for a short duration, with less opportunity to search. The writers borrowed these ideas on search costs from Alan Sorensen and his influential *Journal of Political Economy* study published in 2000.

When a household faces a sudden cash constraint, which purchase is more likely to be deferred? The expensive, unplanned, unsearched item. That is what was found in the data. Using a difference-in-differences design accounting for dynamic region, company and illness variations at the molecule level, it was found that sales volume for acute drugs fell by nearly 3.6% and value by 3.1% relative to chronic drugs. This was not driven by products exiting the market or by price hikes - the number of unique SKUs and inter-quartile range of prices remained unchanged. It was a pure intensive margin contraction.

> Research shows the hidden public health costs of India's demonetisation and the importance of liquidity

Two alternative explanations did not hold. Prescription data from IQVIA, a global provider of health information and analytics, and outbreak data from the Government of India's Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme (IDSP) showed no break in prescription trends or acute disease outbreaks around the time of demonetisation.

The paper by these writers overall complements the literature that has found small or zero elasticity of health care to wealth shocks in insured, developed economies in prior work. In a setting such as India with high out-of-pocket expenditure, cash can essentially be binding for essential purchases.

Lessons for the future

Overall, the study highlights global lessons for any economy contemplating such measures. First, while the stated objectives for currency replacement may differ, cash dependence is similar. Das *et al.* ask whether going cashless made one tax-rich, finding only modest tax gains in the Indian experiment in a paper in the *Journal of Public Economics*. Understanding welfare costs upfront is also important. The implication is not about intent – which was to address legitimate policy concerns – but about distributional impact. Essential medicines behaved differently from other goods. Search costs matter for essential goods. The test by these writers covering product characteristics, inventory-channel, physician behaviour and price rigidity ruled out several competing explanations. While observational data cannot rule out all mechanisms, the search-cost interpretation is consistent across checks. It complements work on price elasticity and transparency.

Second, a public health buffer helps. Complementing AIOCD with HMIS public health centre data, we find areas with lower public health infrastructure saw larger declines.

Physician behaviour and disease incidence did not change, but poorer, under-served regions consumed fewer acute drugs. Thus, PHC density mitigated the shock. Post-2016, India has significantly expanded Jan Aushadhi Kendras, AB-PMJAY, and UPI-based payment options at pharmacies, which improve resilience for future shocks. Explicitly incorporating a health-sector protocol – for instance, ensuring credit lines or digital payment facilitation at pharmacies – during any large-scale currency operation would be prudent. Prior literature on out-of-pocket payments underscores this.

Need for better data

Third, there needs to be better data to measure welfare. The analysis by these writers captures drug sales, but not household-level health outcomes due to data limitations. Ten years later, building linked consumption-health datasets and, where such extreme instruments are considered, requiring a pre-registered evaluation protocol would enable more precise causal estimation.

On November 14, 2016, an economist wrote: "ATM lines are long, but PayTM is up. Should be fine." For many, it was. Digital adoption did accelerate as economists like Crouzet *et al.* have documented and counterfeit stock was reduced overnight. For the mother in Bihar however, deciding whether to buy Amoxycillin that week, the data suggests it was harder.

Liquidity, these writers' findings suggest, is an economic determinant of health. Recognising this can help make future monetary and public health policy more resilient and inclusive.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Official explanation

The report, "Tiger found dead on tracks near Shenkottai" (November 5), with an accompanying photograph, seems to conclude that the tiger was "hit and killed by a train running at high speed", according to the District Forest Officer. A collision with a train running at high speed would either have left the tiger's body severely mangled and strewn along the tracks or thrown it clear of the tracks, with significant injuries. The published photograph does not suggest that either happened. According to the report, the tiger suffered severe head injuries, but its body appears mostly intact and lies between the tracks Could something other than "a train collision" have caused the tiger's death? This requires investigation by the forest officials dealing with this case.

Sridhar Thyageswaran,
Coimbatore

Footballing journey

The retirement of Portuguese football legend Cristiano Ronaldo from international competition at the age of 41 marks the end of an epic era ('Sport' page, November 6).
The running machine terrified and tormented opposition players on the field. His records speak volumes about his glorious contribution to the game.

K. Chellappan,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name.



The Adi community protests against the dam, in Yingkom village in Upper Siang district. They say it will affect at least 40 villages, including submerging 27 of them, and destroy their land and livelihoods. RITU RAJ KONWAR

The Siang dam and a threatened homeland

The Adi community has been protesting against the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project in Arunachal Pradesh, saying it threatens their land, livelihoods, and civilisation. The agitation has turned violent in response to increasing use of force by the State authorities. The community alleges that the State government has used deceit, force, and threats to get consent for the feasibility study. **Abhinay Lakshman** reports on the resistance

A few kilometres from the entrance to Arunachal Pradesh's Parong village, an unpaved road winds all the way down to the Siang river. At dusk, all that is visible at the beginning of the dirt road is the glint of freshly painted yellow barricades of the State police and the shine from the silver of the concertina wires that connect the barricades. The Central security forces who guard the check post here have two purposes – to respond to "unrest" and to stop anyone without "clearance" from proceeding to Siang's waters.

Parong, in Siang district, is one of the three proposed sites identified by the State government for a Pre-Feasibility Report (PFR) to begin work on the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP), developed by the National Hydroelectric Power Corporation (NHPC).

Declared a national project by the Government of India in 2008, it has been opposed by the Adi natives of the Siang, East Siang, and Upper Siang regions of Arunachal Pradesh, with locals coalescing into the Siang Indigenous Farmers' Forum (SIFF) in response to it in about 2012.



The Adi people believe that the 11,000 MW hydroelectric mega-dam project could threaten their livelihoods – which depend largely on paddy farming along the riverbanks and orange orchards – and their homelands, as well as what they consider their last remaining links to their ancestors, culture and civilisational history.

Toto Kombo, 62, from Simong village, says, "My ancestors are buried on the banks of the Siang. These waters link us to the origins of our Adi civilisation. If this dam is allowed, the land we are standing on today will be under water."

> My ancestors are buried on the banks of the Siang. These waters link us to the origins of our Adi civilisation.
> **TOTO KOMBO**
> Resident of Simong village

In the last couple of years, the State government's push to speed up the project by having the PFR conducted for it has come amid reports that China has begun construction on its Medog dam. This project, which is several times the size of the SUMP and billed as the world's largest dam project, is meant to dam the Tibetan Plateau's Yarlung-Tsangpo, the river that feeds directly into the Siang, and eventually the Brahmaputra.

This push to have the PFR study conducted under the justification that it is even more essential to counter China's plans has only been met with increasing resistance from the Adi people. Through SIFF and youth organisations such as SUMP Affected Areas Youth Association (SAAYA), they have sent letters to Chief Minister Pema Khandu declaring their "collective non-consent" for the dam and the study. They have also held public rallies against the project, angered by claims of Bharatiya Janata Party MPs and MLAs that the dam will be constructed at any cost.

Protests and a police crackdown

As opposition to the dam mounted throughout this year, so did the force used by security personnel. On October 4, elderly protesters in Uggeng village, another proposed site for the SUMP, were allegedly lathi charged and 54 of them were injured, along with a Central Reserve Police Force official.

On October 9, prominent anti-dam activists from Geku village were arrested under the Arunachal Pradesh Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 2014. In the weeks that followed, the Arunachal Pradesh police arrested six more anti-dam organisers from Riga, another village that could be affected by the project.

On October 23, a solidarity protest march by youths in Pasighat town was allegedly met with lathi-charging and tear-gas firing by security forces. The march turned violent, ending in mobs setting fire to the NHPC premises. Several youth protesters were detained the next day and another prominent activist and legal advisor to SIFF, Ebo Mili, was arrested. The State government deployed more Central security forces, armoured vehicles, police barricades, and concertina wires, while the SIFF called for bandhs.

Nearly two weeks after the October 23 incident, sitting at the blockade with Kombo and other villagers of Simong, Amoti Nopi, 62, says, "We have been here for 11 days now. We will not move until the government releases our boys who have been detained and arrested for protesting against the project. We have made it clear that we don't want the dam. Then why bother pouring money into a PFR study for it?"

On November 5, the SIFF rejected a fresh invitation from Khandu's office for talks in Itanagar. A day earlier, Dubit Siram, general secretary of the SIFF youth wing in Geku, told a public meeting of villagers, "If they want talks, it can't happen while they are pointing guns at us. First, they have to release the people they have arrested and detained, and withdraw security forces. Then we can consider talks – and that too only if the Chief Minister is willing to come to the affected areas here, not in Itanagar."

The making of consent

Deep inside the jungles of the Upper Siang district, somewhere between Geku and Riga villages, graffiti written in stone on the roads reads: 'No Dam, No Survey'. At a rest stop off one of the bridges over the Siang manned by a large battalion of Rapid Action Force personnel, Jacob Ering, 32, parks his bike and hops into a car taking journalists to a SIFF public meeting in Riga.

Ering is the SIFF youth wing president for Riyu, another village that could be affected by the SUMP. Inside the car, he says, "Our estimates show that the dam will end up affecting 27 villages of Adi communities." He pauses before correcting himself, "Actually, the number could be as high as 40. The 27 villages I am talking about are just the ones that will be fully submerged in the storage area if the dam is built."



As protests have grown, the State government deployed more Central security forces. RITU RAJ KONWAR

During a stop at a helipad on the way to Riga, Ering points to the Siang river flowing below, with Geku village on its banks. Pointing to the hills just downstream of Geku, Ering says, "Do you see those hills? That is one of the potential sites. Can you now imagine what will happen to Geku if they dam the river here?"

Ering joined the SIFF a few months earlier this year. "I could see the fear spreading in our villages. Not a lot of people were willing to speak out against the dam. So, around June this year, I signed up to speak out."

This was around the same time that word had spread in some villages that some families had signed Memoranda of Understanding (MoU) with the State government consenting to the PFR study. "It was in early June this year that the MLA here, Oni Payang, called a meeting at his Geku home, asking people to sign the MoU with the government for the PFR study," says an advocate who attended the meeting. "But none of us in Geku agreed to it." The rumours angered villagers, who vandalised the homes of those suspected of signing the MoU and Payang's residence. Soon after, 34 residents swore in an affidavit that they had not given consent to the SUMP dam.

Siram says, "We have learned that about 600 to 1,000 people's signatures had appeared on these so-called MoUs and now, village by village, everybody is organising to withdraw their signatures from these documents. But now that we are interacting with the people whose signatures had appeared on the MoUs, we are finding out about the deceit of the government."

A copy of an MoU executed by the Arunachal Pradesh government in the presence of Hydro-Power Department and SUMP nodal officers shows that it formalised consent for the PFR study. It also states that signatories would be eligible for a "special relief package" coordinated by the State and Central governments. Further, it notes that the signatories were giving their "irrevocable consent" to the PFR study for the SUMP, adding that the consent for the PFR should not be construed as consent for the dam itself.

The MoUs, starting from September 2025, state they were signed by one member from each village, who had been authorised to represent the "pro-dam" families in the affected villages. The document does not mention when or how these village representatives were picked.

"What is the meaning of this," asks Siram. "How can an MoU be irrevocable? And now that we are speaking to people, we are finding out the tactics used by the government to get these signatures on these documents."

According to villagers across Yinkiong, Riyu, Riga, Geku, Karko, and several others, the signatures on these MoUs were obtained by deceit, force, and through threat of denying benefits of government schemes.

In Riga, villagers say BJP representatives told them that they would get benefits of housing and livelihood schemes only if they signed a paper consenting to the PFR study. In Geku, villagers say they were made to sign blank papers that were going to be for "development schemes", only to find out that their signatures had appeared on such MoUs. In Karko, Akkulung Apang, 31, says he was told he was signing a document for a livelihood scheme that would give him funds to grow and maintain his orange orchard.

"We are finding out more and more about these fraudulent MoUs now," says Geni Nangkar, president of SAAYA. He says in recent months, SAAYA members have been filing Right to Information requests seeking details of those with whom the MoUs had purportedly been executed. But they have been repeatedly stone-walled by the district administration.

On the way to Riga, Ering continues, "The government is splitting us up by just calling these signatories 'pro-dam'. We are finding out that there are no pro-dam families. Government officers have bypassed our community's democratic process of holding village meetings over decisions like this and singled out residents to get their signatures. In some places like my village. the district administration is pointing to signatures of individuals to claim that the entire household has agreed to conduct the PFR."

Ering explains how he is followed by government officials in plain clothes and is often forced to hitchhike to get to public meetings on the anti-dam protests. "We now use trusted people to act as messengers because we don't know whether our phones are being monitored," Ering says.

More than a river

Tabiram Tatin sits in his home at Boleng outside Riga village and sips a cup of black tea. Originally from Riga, Tatin, who has now been serving as the SIFF action committee's chairperson for six years, says, "The legend goes that our tribe was guided by the Siang to these prosperous valleys from regions of Tibet, where we continue to have ancestral ties. Our civilisation's history in these valleys began in Riga village, which is now threatened by the SUMP."

According to oral histories of the Adi community, it was Riga where the tribe settled first when they arrived at these parts of the Siang valley. It was also from here that the tribe started prospering by using the Siang's waters and fertile banks for terrace farming of paddy and other crops, before branching out to various parts of what is now Arunachal Pradesh and other north-east States.

"The Siang is everything for us. The river has been the centre of our culture and faith ever since we found it. The Siang and its waters have not just given us the ability to farm these lands, but also the faith to build our homes, and every single natural produce that we consider sacred and use as part of Donyi Polo, our religion."

Tatin mentions the growth of Ridin, a grass used in a thread that people of the Adi community tie around their wrists. "This does not grow anywhere else. We don't know if it will grow in other lands," he says. "If we are displaced from these lands, how will our future generations maintain the everyday traditions that are linked to the river and the geography of this place? Our culture is anyway under threat from modernity and, in some places, Christian proselytization."

> How can an MoU be irrevocable? Now that we are speaking to people, we are finding out the tactics used by the government to get these signatures on these documents.
> **DUBIT SIRAM**
> General secretary of the SIFF youth wing in Geku

Tatin says he reads the State government's push to get the PFR study for the SUMP conducted as "the last and final attempt". He says the project, planned for more than a decade, has only faced resistance. "When you see the kind of forces they [the State government] have deployed, the kind of tactics they are using to divide our people, and the deceit with which they are trying to manufacture consent, I can't help but think it is a desperate last attempt of the government to get the project off the ground."

The State government's efforts to get public consent for the PFR study, and its treatment of communities opposing the dam and the study, have led more locals to question its reasons for pushing the project. While some, such as Kombo, have started to ask why the villagers should be paying for the Government of India's failures to negotiate with China for an international water treaty, others, such as SIFF General Secretary Likeng Libang, have begun countering the narrative that the mega-dam project is the only way to bring development and generate power.

"Last year, there was a meeting with the government, where the SIFF proposed the alternative of damming the smaller tributaries of the Siang to generate power. This alternative has the potential to generate at least twice the amount of power that the SUMP aims to," Libang says, even as the newly appointed SIFF president Nabeng Burang asks whether the Centre is even aware of the State government's tactics in the region.

Villagers argue that the people of the Siang region want development, but "not through this mega dam that will drown our villages". Nopi, of Simong village, says, "We have no problems with smaller dams that do not pose as much risk to our lands."

Even as the government, through op-eds, argues that the SUMP is crucial to counter China's plans for the Medog dam amid its refusal to engage in international treaties, Adi villagers believe that there is an ulterior motive behind the Khandu-led government's efforts. Many in the region link what they see as the government's "desperation" to build the dam to a soft loan the Arunachal Pradesh government took from NHPC to revive the State's cooperative Apex Bank, months after Dorjee Khandu, Pema Khandu's father, took oath as Chief Minister in 2007.

Kaling Jerang, a longtime activist-politician of the region, who is now vice-president of the People's Party of Arunachal, the biggest ally of the Khandu-led government, says, "There is no account of how much the Arunachal Pradesh government owes the NHPC, with interest, after all these years. In addition, when I started the Save Arunachal Forum, we had revealed how the Dorjee Khandu-led government had signed as many as 143 MoUs and MoAs ((Memorandum of Agreements), opening up the entirety of the State's river systems to potential hydro-power projects, a majority of which never took off." This, he says, begs the question of whether the current government is now being forced to pay for the mistakes of Dorjee Khandu's government. "What else could explain the force with which the government is pushing for this project?"

He further argues that the root of the problem with State authorities exploiting Arunachal Pradesh's river systems goes back to Article 371(h) of the Constitution, which failed to build protections that were encoded for States such as Nagaland and Mizoram.

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Fighting cancer: For patients undergoing prolonged treatment, the expense is not limited to the principal chemotherapy or targeted drug. Supportive medicines, growth factors, antiemetics, and pain medication add to the bill. K. MURALI KUMAR

The endless battle for affordable cancer care

Advances in oncology have improved treatment options, but their benefits remain out of reach for many patients who cannot afford to complete the prescribed course. This is despite the recent decision to cap trade margins on 137 identified non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines providing some relief, writes **Afshan Yasmeen ...**

A 45-year-old garment factory worker from Bengaluru Rural diagnosed with stage IV-A cancer of the mouth faces an arduous course of treatment: chemotherapy to shrink the tumour, extensive surgery involving reconstruction, followed by radiation and chemotherapy. The cost of medicines and supportive drugs of around ₹93,000 alone, besides treatment costs, are staggering for her family with a modest monthly income of ₹28,000. With funds running out, she is facing the risk of discontinuing the final stages of treatment.

Likewise, a 56-year-old shopkeeper from Mysuru district, diagnosed with recurrent, inoperable hypopharyngeal cancer involving the oesophagus, has a different but equally difficult challenge. After three cycles of chemotherapy, the disease has shown partial response. Immunotherapy could offer another treatment option, but its cost remains prohibitive. Spending another ₹2.4 lakh to ₹8 lakh over the next 2 to 3 months for bi-weekly immunotherapy is virtually impossible on a ₹45,000/month income.

Doctors said these cases illustrate the financial strain that accompanies cancer treatment, particularly when care involves several cycles of chemotherapy, surgery, radiation, and newer targeted or immunotherapy drugs. While advances in oncology have improved treatment options, their benefits remain out of reach for many patients who cannot afford to complete the prescribed course.



The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority's (NPPA) recent decision to cap trade margins on 137 identified non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines has raised hopes of some relief. The order, which will take effect on November 9, has capped the trade margin at 30% of the price to the retailer. The Centre estimates that this could lead to an annual saving of around ₹2,500 crore for those seeking cancer care. Prices of some medicines are expected to fall by up to 70%, though the reductions will vary across formulations and brands.

The inclusion of medicines used in newer cancer treatments, including targeted therapies and immunotherapy, is significant. However, oncologists and patient-access advocates cautioned that controlling trade margins is only one part of the larger challenge. High manufacturer-level prices, limited availability of affordable alternatives, and the cost of treatment beyond medicines continue to affect patients' ability to remain on therapy.

For Karnataka, the decision also follows sustained concern over the steep differences between the purchase price and printed maximum retail price (MRP) of several cancer medicines and consumables.

Karnataka flags steep markups

On September 23, 2026, Karnataka's Health Minister U.T. Khader wrote to Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda seeking intervention over pricing discrepancies involving 253 medicines and consumables. The State flagged instances in which the difference between the landing cost and printed MRP was substantial, arguing that the burden ultimately fell on patients already facing high treatment expenses.

> At Kidwai, around 22,176 new patients are registered annually, apart from over 3.7 lakh follow-up visits
>
> **R. KRISHNAPPA**
> Kidwai director

Mr. Khader cited investigations by the Karnataka Food Safety and Drug Administration that revealed how pharmaceutical companies are supplying medicines to hospitals at heavily discounted institutional (landing) prices, while patients are being billed at or near the printed MRP – resulting in markups ranging from 10 times to over 52 times the actual procurement cost.

The examples cited in the communication to the Union Minister included Gufipol, manufactured by Criticare, with a landing cost of ₹86 and MRP of ₹4,528; Guficycline-50, with a landing cost of ₹160 and MRP of ₹7,110; and Terlitis, with a landing cost of ₹118 and MRP of ₹4,416. Other examples included Taxocare 120 mg, with a landing cost of ₹1,000 and MRP of ₹21,617; Canmab 440 mg, at ₹6,600 and ₹57,457, respectively; and Bevatas 400 mg at ₹5,850 and ₹62,690, respectively.

The State sought a review of the pricing mechanism and measures to prevent excessive markups. The figures drew attention to the wide gap that can exist between procurement costs and printed prices, particularly in a sector where patients often have little choice but to purchase medicines prescribed as part of a time-sensitive treatment regimen.

Mr. Khader's intervention has come against the backdrop of rising cancer burden in the State. Data furnished in the Rajya Sabha in August 2026 estimated that Karnataka's annual cancer incidence increased from 88,126 cases in 2021 to 97,130 in 2025, a rise of about 10.2%. Estimated cancer deaths increased from 48,290 to 53,253 during the same period. In 2025, Karnataka accounted for about 6.2% of the country's estimated new cases and 6.1% of cancer deaths.

The figures represent annual estimates of new cases and deaths, and not the total number of people living with cancer. At the State-run Kidwai Memorial Institute of Oncology, where BPL patients get free treatment and drugs, around 22,176 new patients are registered annually, apart from more than 3.7 lakh follow-up visits, said Kidwai director R. Krishnappa.

Financial toxicity of cancer treatment

U.S. Vishal Rao, Head and Neck cancer surgeon and member of the Karnataka Health Department's Vision Group for Cancer, said patients and doctors are confronted with two challenges at the same time: the disease and the financial consequences of treating it; and then simultaneously, the biological malignancy of the tumour and the 'financial toxicity' of the treatment, he said.

For patients undergoing prolonged treatment, the expense is not limited to the principal chemotherapy or targeted drug. Supportive medicines, growth factors, antiemetics, and pain medication add to the bill. These can account for up to 30% of the total treatment cost, said Dr. Rao.

The financial pressure can affect treatment decisions. Some patients discontinue treatment after two or three cycles, delay the next cycle or extend the interval between treatments because they cannot mobilise the money required. This can undermine the benefits of treatment that may otherwise have been effective.

Price cap by NPPA*

Some of the cancer drugs flagged by Karnataka where extreme pricing anomalies have been identified

Drug/Consumable	Landing Cost (₹)	MRP (₹)	Markup
Gufipol (Criticare)	86	4,528	52.6 times
Guficycline-50 injection (GUFI)	160	7,110	44.4 times
Terlitis (AEQU)	118	4,416	37.4 times
Taxocare 120 mg (Intas)	1,000	21,617	21.6 times
Canmab 440 mg	6,600	57,457	8.7 times
Bevatas 400 mg injection	5,850	62,690	10.7 times

*NPPA: National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority

"When we look at the balance sheet of a middle-class family in Karnataka earning ₹25,000 to ₹45,000 a month, a single vial of an overpriced chemo or supportive drug can wipe out their grocery and education budget for the quarter. In private tertiary centres, the cumulative cost of Paclitaxel, Cisplatin, growth factors, and pain medications during a four-month mouth cancer treatment easily crosses ₹1 lakh just on pharmacy bills," said Dr. Rao.

In head and neck cancers, treatment is rarely a single intervention. It can involve chemotherapy to reduce the tumour, complex surgery and reconstruction, followed by post-operative chemoradiation. Each stage brings additional expenses, and patients who have exhausted their savings during the initial treatment may struggle to complete the subsequent phases. "Head and neck cancer treatment is a marathon process involving neoadjuvant chemotherapy to shrink massive mouth tumours, complex surgery, and post-operative chemoradiation," Dr. Rao said.

The price intervention could improve treatment compliance and reduce the risk of patients abandoning therapy. "By capping the prices of these vital drugs, the government is not merely reducing the cost of medicine, it is directly improving survival rates, treatment compliance, and the socio-economic stability of thousands of households across Karnataka and the country."

Advanced therapies

Now, the next priority should be to make advanced therapies and targeted treatments accessible beyond patients who can afford high-priced medicines. Patients from far and near often travel to Bengaluru for specialised cancer care, adding travel, accommodation and loss of income to their treatment expenses.

"The next frontier is making bi-weekly immunotherapy and targeted agents like Cetuximab equally affordable so that no patient is denied a second chance at life due to financial exhaustion. Early detection at the grassroots level is also essential as diagnosis at an earlier stage can reduce the need for more complex and expensive treatment," he added.

Dr. Krishnappa said he has appealed to the State Health Department to include immunotherapy drugs under the Ayushman Bharat-Arogya Karnataka (AB-ArK) scheme. "As of now, this is not covered and the exclusion is forcing poor cancer patients to either bear high treatment costs or go without newer therapies," he said.

An analysis by the Working Group on Access to Medicines and Treatments pointed to the limits of relying on trade-margin regulation alone.

The group examined 643 product entries in the revised price data. Of these, 484 entries, or 75.27%, recorded price reductions, with an average reduction of 50.78%. The remaining 159 entries, or 24.73%, showed no change.

The combined MRP value of the listed products fell from about ₹2.51 crore to ₹2.17 crore, a reduction of approximately ₹34.57 lakh, or 13.8%. Products whose prices remained unchanged accounted for 86.2% of the combined revised MRP value. The group cautioned that these calculations are based on the listed product entries and are not weighted by sales volumes, prescriptions, or actual patient use. They, therefore, cannot be treated as an estimate of the savings patients will receive. The analysis nevertheless indicated that substantial price reductions in several products coexist with high prices for a significant share of the listed value.

The group also found that 56 medicines had a single manufacturer or supplier, with almost all corresponding brand entries remaining unchanged. Where there is no meaningful competition, controlling trade margins may have limited effect on the underlying price.

Its central argument is that margin regulation addresses the distribution chain but does not necessarily bring down the price set by manufacturers. This is particularly relevant for patented and single-source medicines, where patients may have few alternatives.

The group has called for closer scrutiny of manufacturer pricing calculations, affordability assessments and measures to address high prices where competition is absent. It has also raised the need to examine options such as compulsory licensing in appropriate cases and to regulate the overall charges associated with cancer treatment.

Pavan T. Sugoor, associate professor of Surgical Oncology at Kidwai, said the financial consequences of cancer are particularly severe for young patients. "A cancer diagnosis in a young person is not merely a medical event. It can interrupt education, derail careers, threaten financial independence, and place enormous emotional strain on families," he said.

He described the NPPA intervention as an important step, but argued that price regulation must be accompanied by stronger public procurement and institutional mechanisms to ensure that lower prices translate into affordable treatment.

Public hospitals could use pooled procurement, competitive tendering, and negotiated pricing to improve their bargaining power. The availability of subsidised targeted therapies and immunotherapy drugs in government cancer centres would also help patients who cannot afford treatment in the private sector.

Pooled procurement

The National Cancer Grid's pooled procurement pilot, which covered 40 high-value oncology and supportive-care medicines across 23 centres, demonstrated the potential for substantial savings against MRPs. Such mechanisms need to be strengthened and expanded, Dr. Sugoor said.

He also pointed to the importance of quality assurance, proper storage, traceability, and continuity of supply. Lower prices will offer little relief if hospitals face stock-outs or are forced to make emergency purchases at higher rates. Monitoring should therefore extend to medicine availability, treatment delays and patients' actual out-of-pocket expenditure.

The private sector, too, needs greater transparency. Patients should receive written estimates of treatment costs, clear bills, and access to financial counselling so that they understand the likely expenses before beginning treatment, he said.

Evidence from treatment-cost studies underlines the scale of the problem. A prospective study by Tata Memorial Centre involving 500 breast cancer patients found that the average out-of-pocket expenditure was about ₹1.86 lakh, accounting for 72.2% of the recorded total treatment cost. Financial assistance was common, but often insufficient to meet the full expense.

Dr. Sugoor said access to effective treatment cannot be measured only by whether a drug is available or whether a price has been reduced. "The availability of an effective treatment means little if a patient cannot afford to receive it. Scientific progress must therefore be accompanied by policies that ensure its benefits reach those who need them the most." The NPPA order is an important intervention in a treatment area where costs can be overwhelming. But its impact will depend on how effectively the revised prices are implemented, whether savings reach patients, and whether hospitals and pharmacies maintain adequate supplies, the doctors added.



From delicate detailing to using decades-old moulds, the women of Hupari are the backbone of its famed silver ornament craft, passing their mastery from one generation to the next.
RADHESHYAM JADHAV

The silver hands of Hupari

In Maharashtra's Hupari town, women artisans drive a ₹1,000-crore silver industry, sustaining a century-old trade. **Radheshyam Jadhav** reports on how, despite being underpaid and excluded from formal leadership, they forge their own economic autonomy in a deeply traditional landscape

On an afternoon just about a month before Deepavali, Kanchan Katkar, 76, deftly picks up silver *ghungroos* with a pair of iron tongs that fit into her palm. She attaches them to chain loops. "I have been doing this for decades and will continue to do this as long as I am able," she says, her voice bearing a gentle tremor. Deep inside her dimly lit house, hidden within the twisting lanes of Hupari town, where rooms line up like wagons on a track, Katkar sits in the shadows.

Back in 1970, Kanchan was one of the few girls who completed school in Hupari. Marriage then was taken for granted, but after her two sisters wed, she decided to stay single to care for her parents, who had actively participated in the Indian freedom struggle.

Her decision sent shockwaves through her family and village, breaking an unwritten social code. "Why should only a son bear the responsibility of caring for ageing parents?" she says. "Why can't daughters?" Had she ever agreed to marry, it would have been on one non-negotiable condition: that her parents remain her primary care and priority. Eventually, her parents accepted her choice.

"I learnt sewing and soon entered the silver industry," Kanchan remembers. "For any woman seeking autonomy and control over her own life and resources, the very first step is economic self-reliance. Hupari's silver trade gave me and many others that foundation."

Decades later, Kanchan is neither a factory owner nor a trader. Like thousands of women in her town, she works from home, fitting delicate craftsmanship into the quiet spaces between her daily domestic chores.

In the bustling lanes of Hupari, a town in Kolhapur district celebrated for over a century as Maharashtra's Silver Capital, the soft clinking of delicate ornaments carries a quiet story of women's liberation and financial independence.

Here, in an industry generating an annual turnover of ₹1,000 crore, women comprise 60-70% of the town's 25,000-strong artisan workforce, say records of the Chandi Karkhandar Association (Silver Manufacturers Association), whose members comprise 4,000 or so silver-business owners. A publication brought out by the association says the industry began here in 1904.

> For any woman seeking autonomy and control over her own life and resources, the very first step is economic self-reliance. Hupari's silver trade gave me and many others that foundation
>
> **KANCHAN KATKAR**
> Silver worker, Hupari

Silent labour

While men traditionally handle heavy, factory-bound tasks like melting silver, rolling strips, and soldering broad frames, the heart of Hupari's silver industry beats inside the homes of the women. Across the town's winding alleys, populated by about 40,000 people, a domestic production model thrives on women's quiet labour fuelling the local economy, with a national supply chain and exports around the globe.

The town is India's prominent producer of seamless *ghungroos*, the tiny tinkling beads that define traditional *payals* (anklets).

Artisans shape and seal these hollow silver spheres by hand. But they also produce several other pieces of jewellery, including anklets, toe rings, and waistbands.

The production cycle begins with molten metal in factory crucibles operated by men. Women use different techniques to finish the ornaments. Using *jaali* (filigree) techniques, they twist, bend, and mould fine silver wires into complex geometric and Nature-inspired motifs. Their fingers coil thin wire into individual rings, assemble foundational chains, thread beads, link loops, and align delicate charms. They also use *meenakari* (enamelling) to inject colour into grooved motifs. In this way, they turn industrial output into a living cultural legacy.

Despite hours of painstaking labour, many earn between just ₹200 and ₹250 a day, largely because there are no organised labour unions to demand higher wages or fair returns for their work. The piece rate remains meagre: for 2,000 *ghungroos*, an artisan gets ₹400. While a few women manage to complete 2,000 beads in a single day, many make far less, underscoring the gap between their vital craft contribution and their financial compensation.

Those at the helm of the industry acknowledge this reality. Dinkar Sase, vice-president of the Chandi Karkhandar Association, admits that, "*Ha udyog mahilanchya jivavar chalala ahe* (This entire industry rests on the shoulders of women)." Founded in 1944, the association kept its doors firmly closed to women for seven decades, opening membership to female manufacturers only in 2014. Even today, though women run manufacturing units, their husbands often step forward as the public faces of membership.

"Now, the picture is slowly changing and more women are becoming members," says Dinkar. The irony is embedded in the trade's identity: the association's annual report likens Hupari to a *saubhagyarupi nari*, a woman who embodies grace, marital bliss, and auspiciousness, under the spiritual gaze of the village deity, Goddess Ambabai.

According to Dinkar, female artisans require no formal training because the craft flows naturally through generations of hands. Yet, leadership stays entrenched in male hands.

Almost 8,000 manufacturing operations are male-dominated at the commercial front, with men travelling to trade ornaments across Indian cities, while women manage the daily operations back home.

Since its inception, the association has relied on unanimous decisions led entirely by male presidents. Dinkar maintains that wages are settled collaboratively without dispute, and that the association resolves any grievances without distinction between owners and workers. He says the industry's latest challenge is meeting Gen Z's growing demand for fresh, trend-forward silver ornament designs.

A new direction

Sharwari Waingade, now in her 40s, is actively tackling a shift in a century-old craft. Designing contemporary silver pieces, including oxidised-silver lines, says, "The industry will have to adapt to new challenges." She highlights both the changing aesthetic demands and the need to mechanise parts of production with modern technical knowledge.

Her entry into the craft was unexpected. While pursuing an MSc in Microbiology in Pune, she met Rajesh. Rajesh came from a family deeply rooted in Hupari's traditional silver manufacturing. After they married, Sharwari developed a keen interest in carrying that legacy forward.

Inside a traditional stone-structured house attached to their manufacturing unit, she brings out from the cupboard her latest oxidised creations. "This new format of jewellery was introduced by her," says Rajesh, proudly. He also shows off the antique dies preserved by his family over generations. "We continue to design new pieces based on these traditional dies, and we have a strong B2B clientele for this collection."

As Sharwari brings in coffee, she reflects on her transition into the family trade: "I wasn't aware of this industry initially, but now I'm fully immersed in it and working on new marketing strategies, including expanding our presence on social media."

The industry's impact extends far beyond individual workshops. Rajesh's mother, 64-year-old Ambutai, says silver unit work is woven into the social fabric of the region.

"Any woman in Hupari and the surrounding five or six villages gets work by default," Ambutai says. "It is never the case that there is no work for women's hands here."

Ambutai and other local women run self-help groups to save and manage their earnings independently. Having worked shoulder-to-shoulder with her husband throughout her life, she now works alongside her children. She speaks proudly of Rajesh, who has taken on a leadership role within the industry association.

Silver sparks

Navita (name changed to protect privacy) married into a small ornament-manufacturing family in Hupari 15 years ago. Her father – a mill worker in the neighbouring town of Nippani in Karnataka – had insisted she accept the proposal from what he saw as a prosperous merchant family. She had just finished Class 10, and says she was forced into the marriage.

"But then I accepted the reality of life, and decided to navigate it. I learnt the craft, trade secrets, and also began managing a workforce of five people," Navita says, with a broad smile. "I'm sure that we will grow our business."

Her husband shares the ambition to expand into new markets, though opinions differ on the path forward. When Navita suggests bringing in artisans from Agra to introduce fresh designs and cross-regional techniques, her husband dismisses the idea with a laugh: "I know what needs to be done."

When she opens up about her childhood ambition to pursue an education and how she was married off below the legal age, her husband's eyes widen in alarm. Speaking about these matters to a journalist, he warns anxiously, could land him in jail.

As her husband steps away to negotiate with a trader sourcing small silver idols of Lakshmi for the upcoming Deepavali season, Navita speaks candidly about her broader mission: helping the next generation of women in the craft.

"I had three college girls who came to me to learn the craft," she recalls. "I trained them, and they worked with me for three years. During that period, I insisted they save their earnings. I told them, 'Once you save enough money, you have the power to reject unwanted marriage proposals and choose the partner you want.'"

The advice took root. All three women eventually made their own choices in marriage. Today, with Navita's guidance, they are trying to set up their own manufacturing units in the villages where they now live.

For Navita, breaking the gender gap in Hupari's silver industry remains the ultimate goal. "Generally, male artisans work in the field for a few years and then transition into manufacturers or traders, but women remain workers forever," she says. "This has to change."

Her husband, however, argues that the core of the business requires toughness, which women don't have.

Jayshree Lohar, 51, firmly rejects the idea that women cannot navigate the realities of business. The only thing she feels that needs to be strengthened are women's wings. Lohar and her husband, Prakash, 57, run their own manufacturing unit. Unlike many traditional business families, they chose not to force their children into the legacy trade, encouraging them to pursue higher education instead. Their son completed a post-graduate degree in computer science in the United States and works there, while their daughter earned an engineering degree and works at an IT firm in Pune.

Prakash credits Jayshree for the family's success and their children's independence.

"All these years, she handled almost 50-60% of the work and responsibilities in our unit," Prakash says. "Today, our children have found their own path."

The challenges

It is late noon in Hupari, and the town is abuzz with work as artisans scramble to meet the surging national demand for the Deepavali festival. Kanchan is working overtime to complete her orders. "Women don't complain. We work hard, and don't leave any battle halfway," Kanchan says. "Not because we are born like that, but because the world around us makes us that way. A woman has to stand up for herself."

As young men find employment in the nearby government industrial estate at Kagal town, Hupari's young women have stepped in, with better education than even a generation ago. Yet, behind the festive rush, Hupari's famed silver industry faces severe structural bottlenecks.

Sharp fluctuations in global silver prices routinely compress profit margins for local artisans, while a continued reliance on hand tools restricts production speed and design consistency.

Financial vulnerability runs deep: limited access to formal banking drives small workshop owners into high-risk informal credit networks just to keep their businesses afloat. Compounding these issues are low piece-rate wages and demanding physical labour, which make it difficult to retain skilled artisans or attract younger generations. Furthermore, the absence of direct export facilities and modern digital marketing leaves the entire hub dependent on middlemen, preventing artisans from capturing the true value of their craft.

The industry now pins its hopes for long-term sustainability on the proposed Silver Ornament Cluster and the Geographical Indication (GI) tag Hupari Silver Craft received in 2024.

However, for true transformation to take root, Kanchan and many like her believe the path forward is clear: women must be brought to the forefront and given opportunities to lead new aspects of the trade.

After the Deepavali orders leave Hupari's narrow alleys to sparkle across the nation, the soft clinking of silver will continue to echo in its dim homes all year round.

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Decades of work in Hupari's silver industry has given 76-year-old Kanchan Katkar (left) the financial freedom to live life on her own terms.
RADHESHYAM JADHAV



(Clockwise) Self-defence experts demonstrating techniques for students to defend themselves from attackers at the Zilla Parishad High School in Raptadu; a flexi installed by the family members of Gopika, who was injured in a chainsaw attack by a youngster in her classroom, demanding stringent action against the accused; parents of students gather at the Zilla Parishad High School after learning about the attack. R.V.S. PRASAD

Raptadu school attack leaves parents in state of panic

Despite swift and proactive measures by the Education Department and police in providing counselling to students of the ZPHS and the immediate arrest of the accused, several parents are still apprehensive about their wards' safety at the school where a Class 10 girl was attacked with a chainsaw on October 31, writes **Hareesh P.**

"It all happened in seconds. It was not just shocking; it was terrifying. We ran out of the classroom as he [the accused] attacked our classmate with a chainsaw. There were cries of fear and panic," recalls 16-year-old B. Sudershan, a Class X Section A student at Zilla Parishad High School (ZPHS), Raptadu, who witnessed the brutal attack on M. Gopika on October 31.

The accused, Hemanth, 20, armed with an electric chainsaw, arrived at the ZPHS, went straight to Gopika's classroom, and attacked her in the face and hands, causing grievous injuries. While all the other students ran for safety, Gopika's friend Lakshmi was the only one who mustered courage and tried saving her.

Sudershan explains, "It was around 10:00 a.m., and we were listening to our Maths teacher. It was supposed to be our Telugu class, but as the teacher was not available, the Maths class continued. We heard a machine sound outside the classroom, and within seconds, he [Hemanth] entered and attacked Gopika, who was sitting in the front row."

There were 31 students in the room, and all of them fled within seconds, leaving Gopika in a pool of blood, he says, adding that Lakshmi ran towards the principal's office in pain after sustaining a leg injury. The Maths teacher, S. Raja Rajeswari, went into a state of shock, and it took hours for her to recover and speak.

The school has 22 teaching and non-teaching staff members and 358 students from Classes I to X. Most teachers were drafted for municipal elections (scheduled for November 1) and were absent for election duties.

ZPHS Principal T. Rajeshwari, who has been working at the school for the past year and a half, said the accused took advantage of ongoing construction work. A new building is under construction on one side, and plumbing work is under way in a classroom adjacent to Class X Sections A and B on the ground floor near the school entrance.

"The accused might have entered the school along with the construction workers, and no one suspected him when he walked in with the chainsaw because work was ongoing," she tells *The Hindu* when this reporter visited the school on November 3. Rajeshwari was supervising election arrangements conducted on November 5 for ZPTCs and MPTCs on the other side of the premises when the attack took place.

"The children from both Sections A and B of Class X came running out, shouting, 'Champesedu! Champesedu!' [He killed her! He killed her!]. I thought the children had witnessed a crime outside the school and were terrified. Soon, children from all other classes came running out upon hearing the sound of the chainsaw and the cries of other students," she explains.

Rajeshwari adds that she ran towards the Class X building after some students informed her that the incident occurred inside the school, where she found Gopika lying in a pool of blood.

Following initial treatment at the Government General Hospital (GGH), Gopika was shifted to Manipal Hospital in Bengaluru, while Lakshmi is undergoing treatment at the GGH for her leg injuries. Even as Gopika slowly recovers from the injuries inflicted by the attacker, students at ZPHS are still struggling to cope with the trauma.

> I studied in this school myself, but I have never seen such a violent act here. Previously, the PET used to sit under the neem tree right at the entrance and screen any outsiders entering the premises. Now, the school doesn't even have a PET, let alone a security guard.
>
> **A. RAMALAKSHMI**
> Mother of a Class X student

Police also moved swiftly following the incident. "Even though our personnel were heavily tied up with election duties, we deployed 25 special teams to track down the accused. Using technical evidence and CCTV footage, we traced him to the Atmakur forest area. When our teams closed in, the accused attacked our officers, prompting them to open fire, discharging six rounds," says Anantapur Superintendent of Police P. Jagadeesh.

Hemanth sustained severe bullet wounds to both legs, leading doctors at GGH to perform an amputation on his left leg. News of the police action prompted local residents and civil society members to celebrate by bursting firecrackers outside the hospital.

State government intervenes

Meanwhile, the State government swung into action to assist the students - particularly those in Class X and female students from Classes VIII to X - who were emotionally distressed. Authorities decided to reach out to all students and counsel both them and their parents.

A team of 20 counsellors has been tasked with offering counselling to students and hesitant parents.

C. Lakshmipathi, Coordinator of Mental Health Counsellors under the district's Sarva Shiksha Abhiyaan (SSA), says his team is visiting students and parents to instil confidence and persuade them to resume classes. "We started reaching out to the children by the afternoon of October 31 itself. Not just the children, but several parents are also in a state of shock and afraid to send their children to school," he says.

On November 2, the first day the school reopened after the incident; only 30 students attended. However, attendance rose to 100 on November 3, Lakshmipathi notes, adding that he is optimistic all children will return by November 9. The school was closed on November 4 and 5 due to local body elections and will close again on November 8 for Diwali.

Lakshmipathi adds that the team will counsel all 350 students, with a focus on those in Classes VI to X.

A. Umadevi and D. Yasmeen, members of the 20-person counselling team, note that initially, some parents refused to let them speak with their children. "They were reluctant to send their children to school. This is the first time an incident of this nature has happened here, and they are deeply apprehensive about their wards' safety," they say.

On November 3, male members of the counselling team personally brought several male students to school on their two-wheelers after reassuring their parents.

On the day *The Hindu* visited the school, self-defence techniques were being demonstrated to female students by Dr. A. Murali Krishna, the district's SSA Self-Defence Techniques Coordinator. "On the first day, only two students attended the class, but the count rose to 23 on the second day," he says.

The students were taught practical ways to defend themselves against physical threats. "Learning these techniques helps give girl students a sense of confidence," he adds.

Apprehensions

Despite these measures, parents remain reluctant to send their children back to school. A. Ramalakshmi, mother of a Class X Section B student from Anantapur district's Raptadu ZPHS, says, "I studied in this school myself, but I have never seen such a violent act here. Previously, the PET used to sit under the neem tree right at the entrance and screen any outsiders entering the premises. Now, the school doesn't even have a PET, let alone a security guard. I am not ready to send my daughter back until I am confident her safety is guaranteed."

> The accused might have entered the school along with the construction workers, and no one suspected him when he walked in with the chainsaw because work was ongoing
>
> **T. RAJESHWARI**
> ZPHS Principal

District educational officials confirmed that the school's PET retired a month-and-a-half ago and noted that there is no current provision for full-time daytime security guards in State government schools. The only existing arrangement is a night watchman who guards the premises until morning classes commence.

Parents are demanding the immediate filling of the vacant Physical Education Teacher (PET) post and the appointment of a full-time security guard. Several parents continue to visit the campus daily to inquire about security arrangements.

An orphan, history of disturbance

When *The Hindu* approached psychiatrist and former superintendent of the Government Hospital for Mental Health, Visakhapatnam, Dr. N.N. Raju, to know more about the psyche of the accused and broader picture behind such crimes, he points out that the accused appears to be an orphan from a broken family with a history of disturbance. "The brutality likely stemmed from past trauma, amplified by exposure to screen violence and substance abuse."

Speaking on the broader issue of violent crimes across the country and the Raptadu incident specifically, Dr. Raju says, "A combination of factors can act as a trigger in the minds of perpetrators. A proper background verification often reveals crucial underlying details."

He notes that while every human being is born with certain basic instincts, various factors serve to either suppress or trigger them.

"Factors such as society, family, education, morality, and daily environment dictate whether these impulses are controlled or amplified. If a young person comes from a musical or sports-oriented family, they naturally tend to develop an interest in music or sports because family background plays a major role. Similarly, school education must be holistic, giving students outlets to express their emotions and anxieties. If these emotional needs are not addressed during formative years by teachers, peers, or parents, they turn into frustration that can one day erupt violently," Dr. Raju says.

The psychiatrist also warns against excessive violence depicted in movies and web series. "Repeated depiction of graphic violence disturbs the mind, leading vulnerable individuals to internalise and attempt to recreate those scenes. In many instances, alcohol or drug abuse acts as a final catalyst for acting out," he adds.

Police probe reveals back story

An inspector-rank police officer with 28 years of service in faction-prone areas describes the CCTV footage from the classroom as horrific. "After attacking Gopika, the assailant stepped out of the room. But when Gopika attempted to crawl out, he returned and struck her hands until she collapsed. Fortunately, he left the chainsaw behind; otherwise, he might have attacked anyone who tried to confront him," the officer says.

"'Nidra vastondi anna' [I am feeling sleepy, brother] were the words she murmured when I visited her hospital bed," the inspector recalls, adding that he was overwhelmed with emotion seeing the young girl's agony.

According to the police investigation, for several months, Hemanth had been attempting to pursue Gopika. After she rejected his advances, her parents admonished the 20-year-old and escalated the matter to his sister. "Hemanth likely developed a deep grudge against the girl for refusing his proposal and subsequently planned the attack," the officer says.

He says Hemanth lost his parents three years ago and briefly lived with his sister in Ayyavaripalle, near Raptadu. However, his sister eventually asked him to leave due to his behaviour. Since then, he has been living independently and working at the tomato market in Anantapur.

Interrogations with the accused acquaintances reveal that Hemanth was not heavily built and showed no overt signs of physical aggression. Earning between ₹500 and ₹1,000 a day, he occasionally consumed alcohol with friends but had no prior history of involvement in violent crimes.

Meanwhile, Gopika's health has stabilised following a series of surgeries. "She enquired about her teacher immediately after regaining consciousness," HRD and IT Minister Nara Lokesh notes in a recent social media post, adding that he is regularly monitoring her recovery.

Health Minister Satya Kumar Yadav confirms on Thursday that a procedure on her right shoulder was successful and that Gopika is now able to sit up in bed. "She is showing an interest in standing and walking. Her vital signs, respiration, and blood circulation remain normal, and she has begun taking food orally. Pain management and medication continue via intravenous lines," the Minister states.



A group of girl students having their lunch outside the locked classroom where the attack happened. R.V.S. PRASAD

INBRIEF



Sugar output jumps 9.65 lakh tonne to 12.85 lakh tonne

As many as 184 sugar mills have produced 12.85 lakh tonne of sugar between October 1 and November 5, marking a sharp increase of 9.65 lakh tonne over the corresponding period last year. According to the Indian Sugar and Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA), 136 mills have started operations in Maharashtra and 19 in Uttar Pradesh. With opening stocks of 36 lakh tonne from the previous season, local sugar availability stays comfortable, ISMA said.

DLF, Everstone join hands for ₹3,750-cr. IREO investment

DLF Ltd. and Singapore-headquartered global investment manager Everstone Group have entered into a binding and exclusive term sheet to form a joint venture (JV) to invest in IREO Private Ltd and its group companies in India. DLF plans to invest approximately ₹3,750 crore for a majority stake in the proposed JV, which will hold an economic interest in IREO's Indian entities. Investments in the entities are now held through foreign direct investment (FDI) funds.

ONGC may get Venezuela oil operatorships in 3-6 months

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Company (ONGC)'s overseas operations arm is in advanced talks to acquire operatorship of crude oil projects in Venezuela's San Cristobal and Carabobo projects and expects to finalise the arrangement in the next three to six months, Anupam Agarwal, director (finance) told analysts. ONGC Videsh, the state-owned explorer's foreign operations arm, holds 40% interest in San Cristobal and 11% stake in Carabobo projects.

Bull run on D-Street; Nifty reclaims 25,000 mark

Sensex ended 81,028.02, up 2.17% or 1,718.01 points on Friday supported by a significant improvement in global cues and a plunge in crude oil prices which boosted investor sentiment.

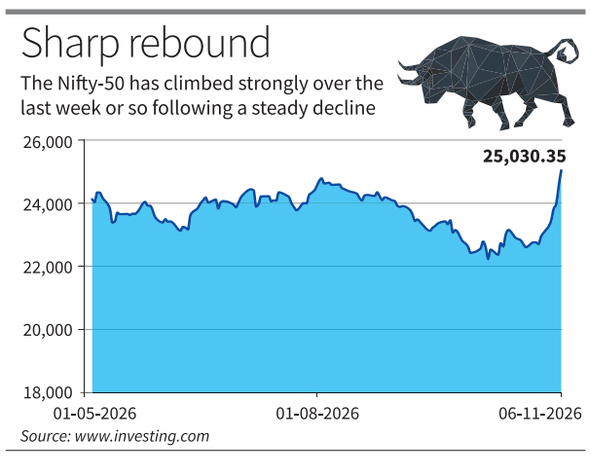
Gowri Lakshmi R
MUMBAI

Indian markets marked the biggest rally of 2026 in the first week of November with the Nifty 50 surging more than 6.8% for the week ended November 6 to settle at 25,030.35, the highest level since March 2. The index extended rally off the October 3 low of 22,179.90 to 12.85% and trimmed year-to-date loss from 15.17% down to just 4.27%.

Meanwhile, the Sensex ended 81,028.02, up 2.17% or 1,718.01 points on Friday. The Sensex was supported by a significant improvement in global cues and a plunge in crude oil prices which boosted investor sentiment.

"Despite the sharp sell-off across global markets, domestic equities demonstrated resilience, supported by strong buying interest in heavyweight stocks. The correction in crude oil prices and recovery in the Indian rupee further supported market sentiment," Pabitro Mukherjee, deputy VP-research, Bajaj Broking said. The benchmark Brent crude posted the steepest weekly percentage fall, down 16% this week, since the pandemic after sweeping victory of the Democrats in the U.S. midterm polls. This renewed hopes for resolution of U.S.-Iran war. Meanwhile, Iran opened up Strait of Hormuz for transit for a few countries, including India.

The rupee strengthened to a six-month high on Friday to below 94/dollar closing at 93.89 on the back of a drop in oil prices, FII inflows and weakness in the dollar index.



Auto retail sales slip 24% in Oct. on high base effect last year

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Total vehicle retail sales in October 2026 fell 24% year on year (YoY) to 31,72,466 units on high base effect a year ago, according to data released by Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (FADA). But October retail sales grew 25.05% from September 2026.

Measured against the extraordinary base, two-wheelers and passenger vehicle (PVs) segments faced decline. Two-wheelers declined 28.35% and PVs 14.23%.

But commercial vehicles (CVs) grew 2.29%, three-wheelers 3.97%, tractors 3.10% and construction equipment 22.07%.

PV retailed 5,07,768 units, 14.23% below October 2025 but 18.86% above September. Two-wheelers retailed 23,21,419 units, down 28.35% YoY.

"The YoY decline is almost entirely optical. Last October was an exceptional month that carried both Navratri and Diwali together over and above the pent-up demand released after the GST 2.0 rate cuts of 22 September 2025; this year Navratri fell in October while Dhanteras and Diwali move to November, according to FADA president Sai Giridhar.

'Second highest'

"Seen correctly, this was still the second-highest October on record – with CVs, three-wheelers and tractors each posting best-ever October – and the 25% sequential jump over September is the truer measure of festive demand," Mr. Giridhar said.

"What YoY numbers conceal is where the decline sits. The sharpest falls are precisely in the most Diwali-dependent pockets – rural with two-wheelers, down 33.97% against urban's 20.77% and the Northern markets – the very segments and regions dealers there now expect to lead November," he said.

"To our mind this is the signature of demand deferred by festival calendar, not demand destroyed: the rural, two-wheeler-led buying that powered last October is set to land in this year's November print," he added.

CVs stood out, retailing 1,15,140 units – up 2.29% YoY and 11.19% over September – best-ever October despite the high base.

Growth was led by heavier trucks. Dealers attribute this to sustained freight movement, infrastructure execution and the haulage of coal, iron ore and e-commerce cargo.


Two-wheelers retailed 23,21,419 units, down 28.35%.

₹12,700-cr. default: Videocon's Dhoot declared 'bankrupt'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) declared former Videocon Industries promoter and director Venugopal Nandlal Dhoot as "bankrupt", admitting the petition filed by public sector lender State Bank of India over default of ₹12,668 crore.

The Mumbai bench of NCLT also appointed a Bankruptcy Trustee to conduct the bankruptcy process against Mr. Dhoot, who gave personal guarantees for loans availed by Videocon Industries from SBI and erstwhile associate banks.

He has been directed to submit statement of financial position to the bankruptcy trustee in seven days from the start of the bankruptcy proceedings.

ADNOC inks 10-year LNG buy/sell pact with Gujarat Energy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) on Friday signed a 10-year sales and purchase agreement with Gujarat Energy to supply up to four million tonnes of liquefied natural gas (LNG) from 2028, further boosting its presence in India's expanding gas market.

The agreement marks ADNOC's fifth LNG supply deal with an Indian company, following similar arrangements with Bharat Petroleum, Indian Oil Corporation, GAIL and Hindustan Petroleum.

Under the agreement, XRG, ADNOC's international investment arm, will supply LNG produced outside the Gulf and owned by it, through ADNOC's global LNG marketing and trading platform.

Jewellery demand to stay resilient in Q3

Gowri Lakshmi R
MUMBAI

Jewellery demand in India is expected to stay resilient during Diwali and ahead of the wedding season. Despite the surge in gold prices, industry leaders say consumers continue to invest and purchase the precious metal.

"Gold holds an extraordinary value in Indian custom. With all the inflation and geopolitical tensions, the public is willing to purchase even at the current levels due to the kind of returns it gives," Rajesh Rokde, chairman, All India Gems and Jewellery Domestic Council (GJC) said.

Mehul Jain, founder of Ekaraa Jewellery, says surge in gold prices has not dampened the appetite for fine jewellery and it has only made customers more strategic about the value.

Dhanteras sales to grow

As per preliminary estimates from GJC, gold business across India during Dhanteras is expected to reach about ₹60,000 crore, reflecting an estimated 15-20% growth in value terms compared with the previous year.

"A positive factor this year is both Dhanteras and Diwali fall at the beginning of the month. By this time, most people would have got salaries and festive bonuses. This resulted in encouraging consumers to shop enthusiastically," Mr. Rokde said.

According to metals analysts and industry players, gold prices are expected to consolidate at current levels.

IT Ministry approves 12 more ECMS projects

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government on Friday approved 12 new projects under the Electronics Component Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS), taking the total number of approved applications to 118 and pushing committed investments to ₹77,051 crore – almost 30% above the original target of ₹59,350 crore. The latest approvals entail investments worth ₹7,503 crore.

Biggest investment

The biggest investment commitment among the new projects is a ₹3,546-crore copper foil facility by Indo Asia Copper Ltd. in Amreli, Gujarat. The incentives under ECMS are turnover-linked with government support contingent on firms starting production. The latest approvals underline the government's attempt to deepen local manufacturing across the electronics value chain rather than be confined to final-product assembly.

"We are going deep in practically every sector," IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said. "Today, we are making, in entire battery, the cell; we are making copper foils, we are making copper clad laminates for PCBs... In a sense, throughout that value chain, we are going deep with each programme, with each approval, we are going deep into that value chain."

A key priority is developing local capabilities in capital gear used to make electronic components, an area where India is dependent on overseas suppliers.

$2.5 tn wiped off Nasdaq 100 as U.S. midterm outcome adds to AI stock slump

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Global technology stocks tumbled on fears the massive infrastructure investments underpinning the artificial intelligence (AI) boom may take longer to build, finance and monetise even as Indian equities bucked the worldwide sell-off with a sharp rally on November 6.

The sell-off, fuelled by concerns over mounting AI-related capital expenditure and uncertain returns, gained momentum following the U.S. midterm polls results. Democrat victories have heightened the prospect of tighter scrutiny of data-centre projects and possible restrictions on new developments, adding to investor anxiety.

Nasdaq-100 plunged 6.36% on November 5, erasing about $2.53 trillion from its aggregate adjusted market value, according to Nasdaq index data. The Nasdaq Composite fell 5.52%, while the S&P 500 and Dow Jones Industrial Average declined 4.36% and 3.44%, respectively.



A screen displays Nasdaq 100 on November 5.

Semiconductor stocks bore the brunt with the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index slumping 12.2%. Nvidia lost about 9% while AMD and Micron Technology shed over 17% each.

Spills over to Asia

The weakness spilled over into Asian markets on Friday. South Korea's KOSPI fell 6.02%, after plunging more than 8% intraday. Japan's Nikkei 225 declined 5.96%, while Taiwan's TAIEX lost 4.51%.

Indian equities, however, bucked the trend. The Sensex surged 1,718 points, or 2.17% to close at 81,028.02 while Nifty50 advanced 2.01% to 25,030.35.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) were net buyers of Indian equities worth ₹14,974.68 crore on November 5 against net sales of ₹10,444.54 crore by domestic institutional investors (DIIs), provisional exchange data across NSE, BSE and MSEI showed.

A Macquarie Research note flagged potential regulatory headwinds for data-centre development following poll outcomes in Texas, Georgia and Ohio, where proposals to impose moratoriums or restrictions on new projects could affect the industry.

Greater scrutiny of power connections, backup-generator emissions, water consumption, zoning and taxation could prolong approvals and raise project costs. The impact may be more pronounced for projects in the pipeline than for facilities that have already secured approvals and power capacity.

NPCI sets up tech subsidiary to tap AI, blockchain, GCC

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has set up a wholly owned subsidiary, NPCI Tech Solutions Ltd. (NTSL), to expand the group's technology capabilities beyond its core payments mandate, with a focus on artificial intelligence (AI), blockchain and digital financial infrastructure.

NPCI also named Vishal Kanvaty as the MD and CEO of NTSL. The new subsidiary will also focus on Global Capability Centre (GCC) services and provide technology services for initiatives such as eKYC Setu and the Unified Ticketing Platform (UTP), besides supporting other Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) programmes.

According to NPCI, NTSL has been established as the technology and innovation arm of the NPCI Group. It will build capabilities across emerging technology domains and support the expansion of the group's technology initiatives.


NTSL will boost NPCI Group's technology capabilities.

Mr. Kanvaty, who has been associated with NPCI for nearly a decade, has led the development and commercialisation of several market innovation platforms that now form part of NTSL's focus areas, the corporation said.

Dilip Asbe, MD and CEO of NPCI, said, "advancements in AI and other emerging technologies are creating new possibilities across digital infrastructure and financial services. NTSL has been established to focus on these opportunities and further strengthen the NPCI Group's technology capabilities."

SP Group unit said to eye up to $200-mn fundraise

Reuters

India's Eqyizen Investment, a Shapoorji Pallonji Group unit, may raise $150-$200 million funds via zero-coupon, rupee-denominated bonds maturing in 2029, bankers said.

"The company will finalise the quantum that it intends to borrow in rupee terms and should be done with the issuance before end of November," one of the bankers mentioned above said.

The bankers spoke on the condition of anonymity while the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) Group did not respond to a *Reuters* request for comment.

In October, Eqyizen Investment had raised about ₹44.50 billion via similar debt issuance at a yield of 18.95% after raising around ₹213.50 billion via another issue at the same yield in July. In both the instances, Mercury Finance, another SP Group firm, raised funds via zero-coupon U.S. dollar-denominated bonds due July 2029 and invested the proceeds in rupee securities of Eqyizen.

TASE Global to get ₹300-cr. investment via ValueQuest's fund

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai-based Trusted Aerospace & Engineering (TASE Global) will receive an investment of ₹300 crore from ValueQuest's Tristar Fund, marking the fund's fourth portfolio investment after first close.

In a statement, Shankar Raman Vaidyanathan, founder, chairman and CEO of TASE Global, said the investment would support the firm's next phase of growth, including capacity expansion, integration of U.S. operations and pursuit of larger OEM programmes.

The firm aimed at becoming a trusted partner for complex, high-value manufacturing across aerospace, medical technology and semiconductors.

Aniket Dharamshi, co-Founder and managing partner of ValueQuest, said TASE Global's manufacturing capabilities and relationships with global customers created meaningful barriers to entry. He added evolving global supply chains presented an opportunity for Indian precision engineering companies to move beyond component supply and become integrated manufacturing partners.

The investment follows Tristar Fund's recent fundraise of over ₹2,100 crore in commitments within 15 months of its first close. Spark Capital acted as the exclusive financial adviser to TASE Global on the transaction, the release said.

TASE Global operates an integrated precision manufacturing platform across India and the U.S., supplying global original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) and Tier-1 suppliers in the aerospace, defence, medical and industrial sectors. Its capabilities include high-precision machining, complex component manufacturing, sheet-metal fabrication and precision assemblies.

The firm said it has established relationships with global clients, including Roche, PerkinElmer, Honeywell, Collins Aerospace, GE and BAE Systems.

TEHRAN

Iran Guards say two oil tankers caught fire in the Strait of Hormuz



REUTERS

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said on Friday that two oil tankers caught fire in the Strait of Hormuz, a day after Tehran claimed five other tankers had similar fates. "The two tankers had deactivated all of their navigation and identification systems and were attempting to exit the strait," it said in a statement. AFP

LONDON

London police chief expects 'many more' plaints against Russell Brand



REUTERS

The chief of London's Metropolitan Police said on Friday "many more" women might come forward with accusations against Russell Brand, after he was convicted of rape and sexual assault on Thursday. He was remanded in custody and told by judge he faced a "significant custodial term" at his sentencing on Monday. AFP

BENI

IS-linked militants kill at least 33 in eastern Congo village attack



AP

Islamic State-linked militants killed at least 33 people in an overnight attack on a village in eastern Congo, burning and looting homes, a local civil society group said on Friday. The attack on Cantine, in North Kivu province, was blamed on the Allied Democratic Forces, or ADF, said a local civil society group. AP

WASHINGTON

U.S. measles cases climb above 5,000 for first time since 1991



REUTERS

The United States has recorded 5,182 confirmed cases of measles this year, the highest number in 35 years, according to an official count released on Friday. Measles was declared eradicated from the U.S. in 2000 thanks to vaccination, but in recent years it has made a strong comeback, fuelled by declining vaccination rates. AFP

Israel Opposition makes progress in its move to oust PM Netanyahu

Eisenkot says he expects President to give him the first mandate to try to form a govt.; Opposition partner Liberman lifts his veto on demands that ultra-Orthodox Jews serve in military, opening doors to a once improbable alliance with community

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israel's Opposition said on Friday it was making headway in its bid to oust Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, as one of its leaders lifted his veto on demands that ultra-Orthodox Jews serve in the military, opening the door to a once improbable alliance with the community.

Neither Mr. Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving Prime Minister, nor Opposition chief Gadi Eisenkot reached a majority in the October 27 election, with Israeli society highly polarised over Mr. Netanyahu and worn down by three years of war.



Protesters call for the formation of a Jewish-Arab government during a demonstration in Jerusalem on Thursday. AP

Mr. Eisenkot said he expected President Isaac Herzog, who met party leaders this week, to present him with the mandate to form a government when he makes his announcement on Sunday.

"We have made significant progress and achieved breakthroughs, quietly and modestly, with much still happening behind the scenes," Mr. Eisenkot wrote in an X post.

Mr. Eisenkot, a former military commander whose campaign sought to appeal to secular and liberal Israelis, could form a government with Israeli-Arabs, whose seat count soared on anger towards Mr. Netanyahu's far-right government.

But an alliance with Israeli-Arabs faces strong disagreement from Opposition partner Avigdor Liberman, a one-time aide to Mr. Netanyahu who now sharply criticises the PM but shares his hawkish views on the Palestinians.

Mr. Liberman said on Friday he would not back down on refusing to work with Israeli-Arabs but called for talks with ultra-Orthodox Jews, even though he ran on promises to end their exemption from Israel's mandatory military service. He said it was time to "understand that trying to have everything risks getting nothing".

"This pains me, and I know it pains many others as well. But given the full range of challenges we face today, the national interest of the State of Israel and the Jewish people must take precedence over all other considerations," Mr. Liberman said.

Nithya Raman elected LA Mayor ousting Karen Bass

Agence France-Presse
LOS ANGELES



Los Angeles Mayor-elect Nithya Raman speaks to members of the media as she celebrates her election victory on Thursday. AFP

Democratic socialist Nithya Raman ousted incumbent Democrat Karen Bass to become the next Mayor of Los Angeles, ending a heated race that saw the one-time allies spar over frustration with the status quo.

Ms. Bass called Ms. Raman on Thursday to concede, after the latest numbers showed Ms. Raman with 52% of the vote against the outgoing Mayor's 48%, with three-quarters of votes counted.

"I'm deeply honoured to be your next Mayor," Ms. Raman said.

"I love this city. I believe in its people. The work ahead will be hard, and change will take time. And together, we are going to build a future as extraordinary as the city we call home."

'Pothole politics'

India-born Raman, 45, campaigned in the nation's second-largest city on a platform of "pothole politics" – dubbing broken streetlights and jagged pavements as failures of her predecessor's leadership – while harnessing the anger of younger voters over affordability.

Her victory is yet another in the win column for candidates backed by the Democratic Socialists of America, who have propelled a cadre of left-wing leaders into office in cities across the country as well as Congress.

At least 30 dead in air strikes on market in Yemen: Houthis

Associated Press
CAIRO

Air strikes hit a market in southwestern Yemen on Friday, killing at least 30 people, according to an official with the Houthi (Ansar Allah) rebels. It would be one of the deadliest attacks since fighting resumed between the Houthis and Saudi-backed government forces.

Another eight people were wounded in the air strikes on the market in al-Waziyah in the province of Taiz, a Houthi Health Ministry spokesperson, Anees Alsabahi, said on X.

Yemen's Saudi-backed military and the Houthi rebels traded accusations over responsibility for the deadly air strike on the market. Taiz is mostly controlled by the Houthis, who have besieged the provincial capital, where the Saudi-allied government and its forces are based.



Yemen's Saudi-backed military and the Houthi rebels traded accusations over responsibility for the strike on the market. REUTERS

The authorities affiliated with the Yemeni government in Taiz blamed the Houthis for the attack and said that no air strikes were carried out in the area.

Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said three air strikes hit the al-Hadara market in al-Waziyah in the province of Taiz. He blamed Saudi Arabia for the attacks and claimed warplanes took off from the Khamis Mushait airbase.

Asian parties reject 'unilateral actions', call for respect for international law

Stanly Johny
SEOUL

The International Conference of Asian Political Parties (ICAPP) on Friday adopted the Seoul Declaration, expressing concern over unilateral actions and reaffirming state sovereignty and territorial integrity, while also calling for strict adherence to the principles of the UN Charter amid growing geopolitical tensions.

The declaration was unanimously adopted at the 13th General Assembly of ICAPP, held in Seoul from November 4 to 6, with representatives of 83 political parties from across Asia participating. The summit was jointly hosted by South Korea's governing Democratic Party and the Opposition People Power Party.

International Conference of Asian Political Parties logo.

The plenary sessions of the Assembly, attended by representatives from Palestine, Iran, China, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and others, saw discussions on contemporary conflicts, including in Palestine and Iran. Though there is no reference to these conflicts in the declaration, members expressed "great concern" on unilateral actions, intensifying geopolitical rivalry and weakening international cooperation. It said non-interference in the internal affairs of states, the peaceful settlement of disputes, and the equal status of all nations were essential to maintaining peace, stability and reconciliation.

"We were particularly concerned that in international relations, unilateral actions, the use of the threat of force, and selective observance of international obligations can erode confidence in the international legal order," reads the declaration.

Answering a question from *The Hindu* on whether ICAPP can be a platform for mediation and conflict resolution in Asia, Chung Eui-yong, Chairperson of the ICAPP Standing Committee and former Minister of Foreign Affairs of South Korea, said ICAPP is a platform for dialogue between political parties, and that parties can influence governments in moving towards peaceful settlement of disputes.

"We are not governments. What we can do is influence our governments. The governing as well as Opposition parties should put in their best effort to influence government policies and promote peace," said Mr. Chung.

The correspondent is in Seoul at the invitation of the ICAPP.

Myanmar to conduct byelections next April

Agence France-Presse
YANGON

Myanmar will hold byelections next April, the polling commission said on Friday, encompassing areas where the pro-military Parliament could not previously hold voting due to the country's devastating civil war.

The move indicates the military's increasing confidence in its ability to control territory in the Southeast Asian nation after it claimed advances following a string of offensives.

The junta staged phased elections last December and January, which it touted as a return to democracy following the coup.

After Donald Trump's midterm poll rout, South America breathes easy

NEWS ANALYSIS

Shobhan Saxena
SAO PAULO

On Wednesday, rising tensions in Asuncion, the capital of Paraguay, turned violent as hundreds of thousands stormed the streets to protest locking out of their accounts in the country's biggest bank. As fires burned and people anxiously queued outside the collapsed bank, President Santiago Pena, a former shareholder in the bank, announced his resignation.

But as Congress moved to impeach him, Mr. Pena disappeared amid rumours that he had fled to Argentina – just as Brazilian far-right leader Flavio Bolsonaro did last week before fleeing to U.S. after losing the election to President Lula da Silva. "We have information that he left the country without telling anyone. I think he went to Argentina and sought asylum," said Paraguayan Senator Antonio Velazquez on Thursday.

Just a day after a blue wave swept across the U.S. in midterms election shaking President Donald Trump's administration, the fall of Mr. Pena carries significance beyond the borders of the country of seven million people. Mr. Pena has been one of Mr. Trump's closest allies in the region, having organised the first Conservative Political Action Conference last year in Asuncion, where Argentinian President Javier Milei praised Paraguay's economy as a "model" to follow.

"If the Republicans had retained the Congress, probably we would have seen Washington coming to Pena's rescue. But the situation has changed dramatically in the U.S. and our region," says a Brazilian diplomat, speaking strictly on condition of anonymity.

Former Argentinian President Cristina Kirchner saw it coming as she predicted on November 2 Mr. Trump's defeat and decline of his acolytes in South America. "Paradoxically, the man who did everything he could to help right-wing leaders win elections in Latin America will lose the elections in his own country," she told *The Washington Post*.

The following day, Ms. Kirchner was in a meeting with Brazilian Congressman Andre Janones as they discussed how to mobilise her Peronist party along the lines of Mr. Lula's grassroots campaign he had led in Brazil and defeat Mr. Milei in next year's election.



Reduced to a lame-duck President, Donald Trump himself could now become a jinx for the far-right across South America. REUTERS

Just ten days after Lula's victory and two days after Mr. Trump's rout, the mood across South America is shifting. In his second term, the American President placed the region high on his foreign policy agenda through his "Donroe Doctrine", which aimed to expand U.S. influence in the region in partnership with right-wing leaders. But the midterms, analysts believe, have given a jolt to that strategy. "The results weaken Trump, who will have more pressing concerns like congressional investigations to deal with. This, combined with Lula's victory, could even lead Trump to negotiate tariffs with Brazil," says Rafael I. Ioris, professor of Latin American Studies at the University of Denver, Colorado.

Growing optimism

The sudden shift comes after an aggressive U.S. policy towards South America in the past 18 months, particularly towards its leftist governments. Besides abducting Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro, Mr. Trump targeted Brazil and Colombia with tariffs and visa restrictions, and got the Bolivian Attorney General arrested under the Shield of the Americas project. In Brazil, however, there is optimism that the changed political reality could open a window for diplomacy.

Unlike Brazil, where Lula is firmly in control, its southern neighbour Argentina, where Mr. Milei is aligned with Mr. Trump, faces uncertainty as he prepares to seek another term in 2027.

Colombia, too, could face severe headwinds with the government of its newly elected far-right President Abelardo de la Espriella, who received Mr. Trump's public backing during the Colombian elections, standing on a shaky ground.

The changed political landscape in Washington could also put Flavio Bolsonaro in a rather tricky situation. The Brazilian far-right leader first declared himself to be the "real President-elect of Brazil" before changing it to the "leader of Brazil". With Mr. Trump saying that he had no plans of meeting Mr. Flavio and some Democrats demanding his deportation, Mr. Flavio seems to standing on a slippery slope.

Mr. Lula, meanwhile, was quick to seize on the irony of his running away from Brazil. "Flavio is a jinx for Trump. He landed in the U.S. and Trump lost the election," the Brazilian President joked during a live conversation on Thursday night.

Reduced to a lame-duck President, Mr. Trump himself could now become a jinx for the far right across South America.



Under scrutiny: Brussels accused TikTok of violating the Digital Services Act over its 'rabbit holes' effect. FILE PHOTO

EU tells TikTok to alter 'harmful' For You feed design

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS, BELGIUM

The European Union told TikTok on Friday to change the "harmful" design of its personalised For You feed or risk large fines under the bloc's digital content rules.

The EU warned that TikTok's recommendation system exposes children and vulnerable individuals to potentially damaging content by pushing a stream of videos similar to those the user has previously engaged with.

Brussels accused TikTok of violating the Digital Services Act (DSA) over the "harmful 'rabbit holes' effect", which happens when users are fed related videos based on an algorithm, in some cases leading to more dangerous content.

"The more a user interacts with a certain type of content, the more TikTok's 'For You' feed algorithm recommends similar content. This design can be harmful when such endless and repeated exposure involves, for example, content about sadness, isolation or body image," the European Commission said. Even when users tell TikTok that they don't like certain content, the platform's algorithm continues to suggest similar videos.

TikTok has made some changes to mitigate the risks but they were not effective, the EU said, demanding more radical design changes.

The EU has ramped up its efforts to protect children, launching investigations into the world's most popular platforms under the DSA law – part of the bloc's legal armoury targeting digital giants.

Brussels plans to add to this by forcing social media companies to make platforms safe before children use them.

Democrats gain leverage to counter Trump's influence on Supreme Court

Democrats will block Trump from appointing a 'right-winger' to the Supreme Court, says Senator Chuck Schumer; the White House says Trump will not let them 'pack the court and ruin independent judiciary'; neither of the court's two oldest justices has publicly indicated an imminent retirement

NEWS ANALYSIS

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump led a transformation of the Supreme Court that ushered in a conservative super majority but soon he will confront an emboldened Democratic-led Senate that is preparing to play hardball on his judicial nominations.

Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer, who is likely to return as majority leader next year, promised in an interview with the *Associated Press* that Democrats will prevent Mr. Trump from installing a "right-winger" in the Supreme Court and that they are "not going to allow any crappy nominees" elsewhere in the federal judiciary or in Mr. Trump's Cabinet.

Mounting opposition

Democrats will hold at least 54 seats next year and as many as 56, depending on final results in Mississippi and Alaska, giving them a significant majority to block Mr. Trump's nominees or just ignore them outright.

After years of being on the losing end of highly partisan confirmation fights against Republicans, especially on Supreme Court nominees, Democrats will be under considerable pressure to wield the same type of aggressive tactics.

This all but erases any prospect that Mr. Trump could add to his imprint on the court he established in his first term by naming three of the current justices. In the past, Mr. Trump had mused privately that he could end up nominating up to seven people for the nine-person Bench by the end of his second term, according to a person with knowledge of those comments.

Mr. Schumer declined to say specifically whether he would hold any Supreme Court vacancy open until after the next presidential election, as former Senate Republican leader Mitch McConnell did in 2016, clearing the way for Mr. Trump to nominate the first of his three Supreme Court picks.

"The bottom line is, we're not going to allow a right-winger on the court," Mr. Schumer said.

The White House said on Thursday that "extreme Democrats have a history of politicising the Supreme Court, even entertaining plans to pack the Court with liberal justices."

"President Trump will never let them pack the Supreme Court and ruin the independent judiciary," White House spokeswoman Lauren Bis said.



Shifting equation: U.S. President Donald Trump will soon confront an emboldened Democratic-led Senate that is preparing to play hardball over his judicial nominations. REUTERS

Neither of the court's two oldest justices, Samuel Alito (76) or Clarence Thomas (78), has publicly indicated an imminent retirement. Lifetime appointments generally provide some insulation from political upheaval, even on the scale of Tuesday's elections, in which Democrats regained control of both the House and the Senate.

"I think the justices must know that if they were to retire now, at this moment, right before Democrats take the Senate, there would be an enormous amount of pressure unlike any we've seen, to make serious change to the court," said Dale Carpenter, a law professor at Southern Methodist University's law school.

Justice Alito has publicly mused about retirement in recent months, telling *AP* that he is not sure "how long I'll be able to continue to do this job." But he has also said he will stay on the court through the end of the term next summer and told *Bloomberg* he would not step down during a lame-duck period.

Meanwhile, Justice Thomas is closing in on a record-setting tenure and would become the longest-serving justice in the nation's history if he served until May 2028.

Mr. Trump has shown unusual deference to Justice Alito and Justice Thomas, even as he has attacked other justices who have ruled against him. He has praised both for their legal acumen and declined to say whether they should step down so that the President could nominate their successors.

'Shortlist of nominees'

In a *Fox News* interview in April, Mr. Trump said he has a shortlist of potential nominees but said he did not know whether he would have another vacancy this year, citing Justice Alito's "very good physical health."

The Democrats' sizable margins in the Senate will also hamper the Republicans' effort to regain ground in the 2028 elections, where the GOP will be defending States such as Wisconsin, North Carolina and Iowa where the Democrats made significant gains on Tuesday.

"Chance of confirming a worthy successor to Justice Thomas and/or Alito during President Trump's term: Zero," Florida Governor Ron DeSantis posted on X after Tuesday's elections. "Chance of confirming a worthy successor during a hypothetical GOP admin 2029-2033: probably zero (GOP won't be able to recapture enough seats in 28)."

Historically, some justices have timed their retirements with the President who would name their successor in mind, but it is far from the only consideration in their decision making.

Former liberal Justice Ruth Bader Ginsburg famously resisted efforts from progressives to retire when President Barack Obama was in office and died in the last year of Mr. Trump's first term, allowing him to replace her with conservative Justice Amy Coney Barrett.

Ms. Barrett would go on in 2022 to join the majority opinion in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, which erased the constitutional right to an abortion.

A regal visitor



Stately stroll: A peacock walks past Polish honour guard soldiers standing behind the red carpet ahead of the informal meeting of the Foreign Ministers of the Council of the Baltic Sea States and Ukraine in Warsaw on Friday. AFP

New Zealand sees closely contested election amid economic concerns

Agence France-Presse
WELLINGTON

New Zealand is poised for one of the closest elections in its history on Saturday, as the country votes following a campaign dominated by the cost of living and an economy hammered by the war in West Asia.

Polls suggest that neither the ruling conservative National Party nor the Opposition centre-left Labour have offered a programme compelling enough to win the seats needed to govern by themselves.

Prime Minister Christopher Luxon has hoped that promises of no new taxes will help his right-wing coalition cling to power after three fractious years in office, two failed attempts by his own party to oust him as leader and an economy in the doldrums. Speaking at a rally in Auckland, he urged voters to "stick to the plan that's working".



Campaign trail: New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon attends a poll rally in Auckland on Friday. REUTERS

Pushing to replace him is Opposition leader and former Premier Chris Hipkins, whose Labour party has proposed a sweeping package of measures to help relieve the economic pressure on New Zealanders.

With the polls so close, attention has turned to New Zealand's minor parties – in particular the centrist Opportunity Party.

"It's one of the closest elections, certainly, and one of the hardest elections to predict in my professional life," David Capie, a professor at Victoria University of Wellington, told *AFP*. On the streets of Wellington, many New Zealanders told *AFP* that they were struggling to get by and thinking twice about paying for things they had once taken for granted.

New Zealanders have been able to cast their votes since October 26. As of Thursday, almost 1.7 million people have already cast their ballots.

A final opinion poll released on Friday put Labour at 30 per cent of the vote, just ahead of the National Party.

Zelenskyy seeks post-war security guarantees ahead of talks with Russia, U.S.

Associated Press
KYIV, UKRAINE

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has said that his government is seeking specific guarantees from Western allies on how post-war security support would function when the nearly five-year war sparked by Russia's full-scale invasion of his nation finally ends.

Mr. Zelenskyy's comments in an interview aired late Thursday followed two days of discussions among allies in Brussels that focused on post-war security and reconstruction. They also came before planned talks between Ukraine, Russia and the United States in Abu Dhabi next week, the first trilateral peace discussions since February.

While talks on the contours of peace continued, the grim reality of war remained front and centre in Ukraine on Friday, with more Russian drone attacks and a rising death toll from Moscow's guided bomb strike on Monday on a former school operating as a humanitarian aid distribution centre.

Two days of talks in Brussels discussed post-war reconstruction, funding for 2027 and security guarantees backed by the Ukrainian government's Western allies. The meetings brought together officials from the U.S., U.K., France, Germany and the European Union, along with representatives from the World Bank and the U.S. investment group BlackRock, Ukrainian lead negotiator Rustem Umerov wrote in an online post.

"We separately discussed the threats from Russia to Ukraine and all of Europe, as well as joint steps to counter them," Mr. Umerov wrote.

Need 'tangible results'

In his television interview, Mr. Zelenskyy said he wanted to see tangible results.

"What matters is that it's clear on paper," Mr. Zelenskyy said in an interview with Ukraine's private 1+1 television broadcast late Thursday. "The question isn't dozens of points, but simply an understanding of the outcome: If Russia starts (attacking) again, what will happen? Who will do what, with what means, and when?"

Mr. Zelenskyy said it was important to maintain bipartisan support for Kyiv in the United States but acknowledged that the Democrats' sweeping victories in this week's midterm elections could have a positive effect on U.S. assistance. This includes the faster delivery of Patriot missile interceptors that Kyiv says are vital to fend off Russian airstrikes.



President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's comments came after allies held discussions in Brussels on post-war security and reconstruction. AP

"I believe our chances of getting additional assistance from the U.S may now grow," he said.

'Big agreement'

President Donald Trump met with Moscow envoy Kirill Dmitriev on Thursday, but declined to give details of what they discussed.

"There's going to be an agreement, it's going to be a big agreement and it's going to involve more than Ukraine," Mr. Trump said, adding that it might include all of Europe.

Mr. Trump, who has long boasted that he could quickly broker an end to Russia's war in Ukraine, has lately blamed Mr. Zelenskyy for refusing to make concessions to end the conflict. Mr. Trump did not meet the visiting Ukrainian officials on Thursday, who were also in Washington for a ceremony with first lady Melania Trump.

Mr. Trump's son-in-law and envoy Jared Kushner said in a social media message that the goal of the Brussels talks was to "develop practical arrangements that address the security concerns of all sides, reduce the risk of future conflict and create a more stable and predictable security environment."

The European Union played down expectations for an agreement anytime soon.

"We look forward to seeing it materialise, but there's a lot of work that needs to go into it," European Commission spokesperson Paula Pinho said. The commission hosted the first day of talks at its Brussels headquarters on Wednesday.

"Above all, there needs to be a willingness on the side of the one who first started the war, the one who aggressed," she told reporters, in a reference to Russia. Ms. Pinho welcomed the resumption of talks and what appeared to be "full engagement" on all sides.

The Kremlin on Friday did not comment on Mr. Trump's remarks about a possible deal.

"There are no details," Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters. Mr. Peskov said that Russia had received no ideas from Europe on security guarantees, but added that any discussion of security between Russia and Ukraine would at some point be "impossible" without Europe's involvement.

The Kremlin spokesman accused the European side of "persistent indecisiveness and a lack of readiness," adding that European leaders "haven't even managed to decide who is authorised to speak on their behalf."

Meanwhile, Ukraine's air force said Russia launched 227 attack drones, including 86 jet-powered ones, with strikes reported at 14 locations and debris falling at eight others.

SUSPENSE

Indian team management will take a call on Siraj's inclusion: Ghosh



FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

India's fielding coach Shubhadeep Ghosh refused to divulge whether Mohammed Siraj would be part of the playing XI in Saturday's second ODI against New Zealand in Wellington. "I don't know, the team management will decide that," Ghosh said during the pre-match media interaction.

EXPERIENCED UNIT

Players know how to react to busy schedule: India's fielding coach



CREIMAS/BCCI

India's fielding coach Subhadeep Ghosh played down a query as to whether the hectic scheduling is having a bearing on the players. "It is physically challenging but they have played enough cricket to know how to react to these situations," he said. India will feature in a two-Test rubber against the Kiwis after the ongoing ODI series.

OUT AND IN

Kelly to replace injured Conway for remainder of ODI series



FILE PHOTO

Dealing a big blow to New Zealand in the ongoing ODI series against India, left-handed batter Devon Conway has been withdrawn from the remaining matches owing to the concussion he sustained during training on Tuesday. Nick Kelly will replace him for the second match on Saturday, stated a New Zealand Cricket release.

RESPONSIBILITY

Teenager Sooryavanshi to lead Bihar in Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy



PTI

Teenage batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will lead Bihar's senior team for the first time after being named captain for the opening two matches of the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, beginning on November 14. BCA president Harsh Vardhan said the captaincy would provide Sooryavanshi a chance to grow as a leader.

Onus on rookie pace attack as Team India looks to make it 2-0

Kamboj proves a revelation in the series-opener while Arshdeep and Gurnoor, too, come up with vital blows; Rohit will be keen to get going after falling for a duck; the Black Caps batters hope to bounce back after their insipid show in Auckland



The architects: Kohli did the job for India in the opening ODI after Kamboj's miserly spell went a long way in restricting the Kiwis. CREIMAS/BCCI

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
WELLINGTON

India's inexperienced yet promising four-pronged pace attack will be looking to maintain its upper hand over New Zealand's batters and dictate proceedings to ensure that the visitors extend its lead when the two sides clash in the second ODI here on Saturday.

There were plenty of question marks over India's untested bowling resources heading into the series, but the likes of Arshdeep Singh, Anshul Kamboj and Gurnoor Brar changed that narrative with stellar performances in the series-opener.

Eden Park had shorter straight boundaries. At the Hnry Stadium here, the square boundaries are shorter, requiring pacers to adjust their lengths accordingly. Arshdeep and Co. bounced out the opposition in Auckland, but here, the ground dimensions will encourage them to bowl a tad fuller.

Left-arm pacer Arshdeep had the most wickets (four), but it was Kamboj who was the pick of the bowlers for India with his 46 dot balls. While the others focused on bowling into the pitch, Kamboj was rewarded for consistently hitting Test-match lengths.

Arshdeep and Auqib Nabi opened the bowling at Eden Park, but considering the movement the latter generated, he could also be given the new ball.

On the batting front, Rohit Sharma would be expected to get back among the runs after failing to open his account n Auckland. The redoubtable Virat Kohli's fluency at Eden Park was striking.

However, the other Indian batters were troubled by the short ball and would be looking to sharpen their game. The New Zealand batters, on the other hand, tried to pull their way out of trouble against the short ball but failed miserably.

Skipper Mitchell Santner admitted after the game that his batters were found wanting against the extra bounce.

Good carry and bounce are expected at this ground as well, bringing the fast bowlers very much into play.

Match starts at 7.30 a.m. IST.

Veteran Shami announces his retirement from Test arena

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

Out-of-favour India pacer Mohammed Shami on Friday announced his retirement from Test cricket, bringing an end to a 13-year career in which he claimed 229 wickets from 64 matches.

The 36-year-old, who has been out of the Indian team since the 2025 Champions Trophy, announced his decision through an Instagram post, adding that he would continue to play white-ball cricket.

"I am leaving the white jersey, but never the memories connected to it. When I first wore India's Test jersey, I had only a dream – to do something for my country.

"After that every wicket, every struggle, every injury and every comeback taught me something," Shami wrote.

Special part

"Test cricket is not just a format for me, it is a very special part of my life. Today I am deciding to retire from Test cricket with a heavy heart and unlimited beautiful memories," he added.

Shami made his Test debut against the West Indies at the Eden Gardens on November 6, 2013.

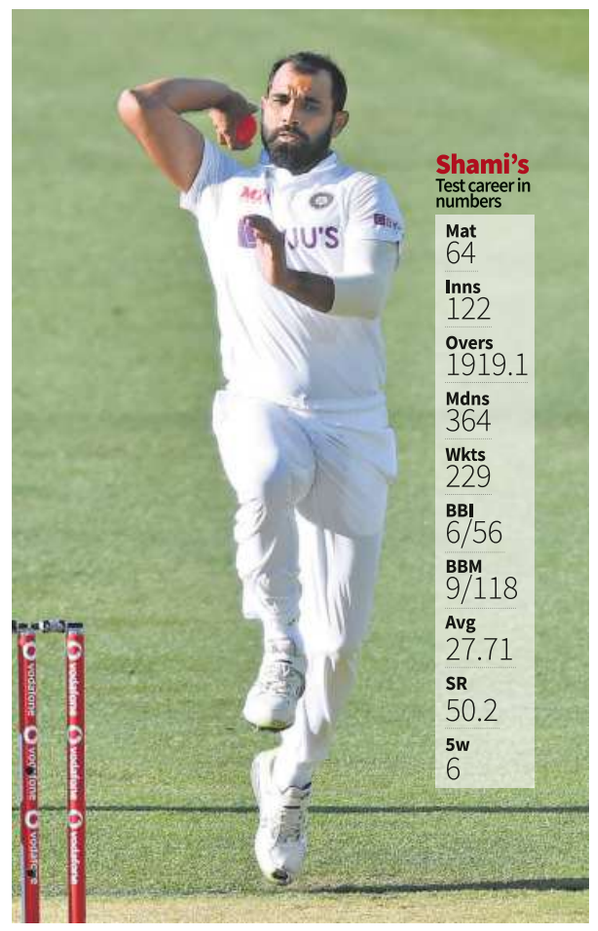
His ability to generate seam and swing with both the new and old ball made him a key component of India's pace attack across conditions.

Some of his most memorable performances came in South Africa.

He returned figures of five for 28 in the second innings of the Johannesburg Test during India's 2018 tour to help the visitor secure a consolation victory.

Shami's last Test appearance came in the 2023 World Test Championship final against Australia at the Oval.

Injuries subsequently disrupted his career, but he remained an important part of India's white-ball set-up.



Shami's Test career in numbers

Mat	64
Inns	122
Overs	1919.1
Mdns	364
Wkts	229
BBI	6/56
BBM	9/118
Avg	27.71
SR	50.2
5w	6

Incisive and impactful: Shami was one of India's finest pacers in the longest format. FILE PHOTO

Super-sub Soham does it for Bengaluru

ISL

Sports Bureau

Bengaluru FC (BFC) clinched a dramatic 2-1 victory over FC Goa in the Indian Super League (ISL) at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Fatorda, Goa, on Friday. Borja Martinez gave the visitors an early lead in the 12th minute before Franchu drew the hosts level five minutes later. Substitute Soham Varshneya then delivered a decisive blow in the third minute of stoppage time.

The victory saw Bengaluru move to third in the standings, behind North-East United FC and Mohun Bagan Super Giant, with a game in hand.

The Blues made a bright start to the contest, demonstrating their attacking intent. Martinez created space before unleashing a clinical left-footed strike from outside the box. His effort found the back of the net to put BFC ahead 1-0.

Goa responded with urgency as Muhammed Nemil picked out Franchu, who unleashed a powerful right-footed strike from distance.

The effort flew past Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, bringing the Gaurs back on level terms (1-1).

The match remained balanced as both sides looked to gain the upper hand. Bengaluru, however, found the breakthrough when it mattered most.

The result: FC Goa 1 (Franchu 17) lost to Bengaluru FC 2 (Martinez 12, Soham 90+3).



In the nick of time: Soham's strike in the 93rd minute broke FC Goa hearts. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Montgomery snaps Maaya's dream run; Vaishnavi-Rutuja in last four

WTA CHENNAI OPEN

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

Robin Montgomery overcame an early setback to defeat wild card Maaya Rajeshwaran 6-3, 6-3 in the quarterfinals, ending the Indian challenge in singles at the WTA 250 Chennai Open on Friday.

The 17-year-old Maaya was quite impressive in the initial exchanges.

She handled the 5'10" American lefty's serve – it averaged above the 180km/h mark – by constantly adjusting her position near the baseline. The Indian got the early break in the fifth game of the opener courtesy a netted backhand from the World No. 151, much to the delight of the 500-odd spectators on the centre court at the SDAT Stadium.

But when it came to consolidating the break, the Coimbatore girl, who had been landing plenty of first serves in the high 170s range, couldn't find one till she was 15-30 down. Montgomery converted the first opportunity to restore parity. Maaya also let the eighth game - in which she committed two double faults - slip after being 40-30 up and was broken again. The 22-year-old Montgomery, former World No. 95, served the first set out. In the second essay, the American was in control as she earned the double break advantage at 4-1. After Maaya retrieved one of them back, Montgomery held quickly for a 5-3 lead and finished the job with a cross-court backhand winner to break the Indian for the third time in the set. Montgomery will now face reigning champion Janice Tjen. World No. 75 Tjen recorded a come-from-behind 5-7, 6-4, 6-2 win over Uzbek Polina Kudermetova in a match that was briefly suspended due to a passing shower.

Vaishnavi Adkar and Rutuja Bhosale kept the Indian challenge alive in doubles with a 7-5, 6-4 win over Montgomery and Great Britain's Jodie Burrage. Vaishnavi and Rutuja moved into the semifinals. However, Maaya and Shrivalli Bhamidipaty lost 3-6, 4-6 to Isabelle Haverlag of the Netherlands and Hungary's Panna Udvardy in a last-eight clash.



Acing it: Montgomery overcame a slow start to power past Maaya. R. RAGU

The results (quarterfinals): Robin Montgomery (USA) bt Maaya Rajeshwaran 6-3, 6-3; Janice Tjen (Ina) bt Polina Kudermetova (Uzb) 5-7, 6-4, 6-2; Magda Linette (Pol) bt Mai Hontama (Jpn) 4-6, 7-5, 6-4; Anastasia Zakharova (Rus) bt Lucrezia Stefanini (Ita) 6-2, 5-2 retd.

Badminton-mad Indonesia and Tjen

Nihit Sachdeva
CHENNAI

"Booking tennis courts (in Indonesia) is a bit tough now."

Without elaborating, Janice Tjen said it all. Indonesia, a country that lives and breathes badminton, is once again warming up to the sport with the heavier racquet.

Tjen's rise is a major reason behind that. She had started the 2025 season outside the Top 400 in the WTA rankings but by the end, she was World No. 56.

Along the way, she also ended a 22-year wait for a win for an Indonesian woman at a Grand Slam during the US Open, finished runner-up at a WTA 250 in Sao Paulo and won her maiden Tour-level title at the Chennai Open.

Unlike last year, where the 24-year-old Indonesian dominated the ITF circuit, this season has been all about getting used to playing regularly on the WTA Tour where the level is much higher.

"This year, I learned so much. Everyone has a lot of expectations of how well they want to do and it's normal to be like that as a tennis player," reflected Tjen, who had a 16-28 win-loss record on the WTA Tour before arriving in Chennai.



Tjen. R. RAGU

"It's an important trait to have and just learning how to be able to bounce back, doing things one at a time and realising that this year, the competition has been way higher for me."

Tjen did have one major highlight this season. Last week, she played doubles with Venus Williams and reached the Guangzhou Open semifinals with the 46-year-old American legend calling it "her best partnership of the year."

"It's nice to hear what she said about our partnership," said Tjen.



GETTY IMAGES

Still searing: how outlier Starc has kept the fire burning

The rangy left-armer is bowling better than ever at 36, operating at rapid speeds and expanding his repertoire. In an era when his unique skill-set warrants big money from T20 leagues around the world, he has gone against the grain: he has preserved himself for Test cricket

Vivek Krishnan

In the life of a genuine fast bowler, the passage of time necessitates considerable compromises.

As strands of grey sprinkle the hair and stiffness stymies the limbs, many cut down on searing velocity. A fair few drift entirely towards white-ball cricket, not as backbreaking on an ageing body as a format requiring hard labour for five days of 90 overs each.

But wouldn't life be boring without outliers?

Straining every sinew

It certainly would, and few outliers are as consistently compelling as Mitchell Starc. The rangy left-armer is 36, the prime of youth distant in the rearview mirror. Yet, the speedster from Sydney, as friendly off the field as he is fierce on it, continues to merrily strain every sinew in the oldest format, wearing his weather-beaten white flannels and battered baggy green cap as a badge of honour.

He remains rapidly fast. Gathering steam as his 6'6" frame glides gracefully over the grass, all his kinetic energy channelled towards the batter on strike, he cranks it up to the high 140s (kmph) on the speed gun as a matter of habit even now. Anything gentler seems to sit uneasy with the Aussie, his penchant for high pace overriding the sober realities of life in the fast lane. In the second innings of his most recent Test, he was clocked delivering a 150.8 kmph thunderbolt.

Starc cranks it up to the high 140s as a matter of habit even now, his penchant for high pace overriding the sober realities of life in the fast lane

In an era when his sui generis skill-set warrants big bucks from T20 leagues around the globe, he has preserved it for the primacy of Test cricket. He didn't play any part in the money-spinning Indian Premier League (IPL) between 2015 and 2024, and gave up T20Is for his country last year after just 65 appearances over 12 years. His ODI commitments increasingly witness long gaps too.

But whenever Australia has a five-day fixture to cater to, Starc, who has looked after his lean physique with the care of a surgeon's scalpel, is the indomitable leader of the pace pack. He will usher in 15 years of Test cricket come December – a feat requiring more than mere lip service about the merits of the classical genre.

The numbers evoke awe. In 110 Tests, he has accounted for 460 victims at an average of 25.97. He strikes once every 45.4 deliveries. No left-arm pacer in the history of the game has a richer tally.

Worthy of admiration in the here and now is Starc's resistance to resting on his laurels. In the third Test against South Africa at Newlands last week, he was the best of Australia's four specialist bowlers, overshadowing Josh Hazlewood, Pat Cummins and Nathan Lyon with nine wickets over the course of the match. His haul of six for 72 in the first innings was the headline-grabbing act.

For somebody so well-versed with striking in the first over of the innings – he has done so 28 times in this format alone – Starc actually endured a sloppy start on the opening day. At tea, his figures of 11-1-60-0 made for insipid reading as Aiden Markram and Marques Ackerman pummelled the red Kookaburra in an opening stand of 158 runs. Starc's signature swing, into the right-hander and away from the left-hander, was absent, leaving his fuller deliveries vulnerable to punishment.

With greater wisdom about the wobble-seam delivery coming into the game in recent years, Starc has levelled up and added another dimension

A younger avatar of the New South Welshman may have been prone to slumping his shoulders on such days. In the words of the late Shane Warne, Starc's demeanour could be "a bit soft" when the going got tough.

The enforcer strikes back

That critique was delivered more than a decade ago. When under the cosh in Cape Town, Starc, a bona fide fast-bowling great of the modern era, came back with a vengeance long before the day's close. In his 13th over, the Australian banged the ball in short and got it to climb to induce errors from David Bedingham and Wiaan Mulder. It spoke of his enduring role as an enforcer despite being the oldest of the three frontline quicks.

When the new cherry became available for a second time, Starc grabbed it with glee under leaden skies. With the overhead conditions favouring swing, he targeted the base of the stumps, made the ball hoop wickedly and sparked the host's slide from 325 for six in 80 overs to 329 all out in 82.3 overs. Six deliveries were all it took for Starc to excise Ryan Rickelton, Marco Jansen, Gerald Coetzee and Kagiso Rabada.

It was a spell reminiscent of the magic that Wasim Akram often produced. In the Pakistani's pomp, the swashbuckling swing maestro could get on a roll at the snap of a finger along with his compatriot and competitor, Waqar Younis. Starc, who went past Akram's figure of 414 scalps during the 2025-26 Ashes, is cut from the same cloth.

His Ashes campaign last summer wasn't just significant for the milestone. It also underlined that his match-winning influence had minimal reliance on his illustrious peers in the pace department. With Hazlewood missing all five Tests and Cummins participating in only one due to injuries, all of the spotlight was for Starc to singularly bask in, as his chart-topping 31 wickets helped Australia retain the urn.

The Ashes exploits marked the culmination of a sensational year for the fast bowler. In 2025, he played 11 Tests and returned 55 wickets at a world-beating average of 17.32. A strike-rate of 28.3 balls per wicket was equally formidable. Never before in his decorated career had Starc been as menacing.

The assimilation of the wobble-seam ball into his armoury has added another dimension. While the delivery darting back into the right-hand batter is his natural go-to weapon, he was never at ease conjuring up the away-swinger.

With greater wisdom about the wobble-seam coming through in recent years, Starc has levelled up. For the element of surprise, he places his fingers at an angle across the seam, and rips down the back of the ball. If it lands on the pronounced seam upon pitching, it tends to nip away. If it lands on the leather, it usually skids on. Either way, it makes for a deadly variation to his stock delivery, and gives no more than a split-second for the batter to react to the late movement.

Preying on an obsession

In his backyard, Starc employed it to devastating effect against England's overzealous batters. Given their unyielding obsession with taking the attacking option under the erstwhile captain-coach combine of Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum, Starc was more than willing to slant the ball across the right-handers and coerce flashy drives.

It translated into a third series win on the trot for Starc over the old enemy at home. Glaringly, he has never won a Test series in England. That will be on his radar with an Ashes tour in the Old Blighty scheduled for the summer of 2027. The defence of the ODI World Cup in southern Africa in October-November next year is another realistic target.

Till then at the very least, Starc will keep the fire burning without compromising on his core ideals. He doesn't know any other way.



STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Alexander Zverev	29	9,550	19
2	Jannik Sinner	25	9,450	16
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	6,100	17
4	Ben Shelton	24	4,530	21
5	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,860	23
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,690	25
7	Arthur Fils	22	3,525	19
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,430	22
9	Alex de Minaur	27	3,410	23
10	Rafael Jodar	20	3,209	20
11	Novak Djokovic	39	3,140	15
12	Taylor Fritz	29	3,095	22
13	F. Auger-Aliassime	26	2,875	20
14	Tommy Paul	29	2,775	22
15	Jiri Lehecka	24	2,580	21

Top Indians



Sumit Nagal
Rank 265 ▲ 4 spots



Karan Singh
Rank 354 ▲ 47 spots

WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	8,099	20
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	6,485	20
3	Mirra Andreeva	19	6,306	20
4	Coco Gauff	22	5,763	20
5	Jessica Pegula	32	5,760	20
6	Elina Svitolina	32	5,121	20
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,665	20
8	Linda Noskova	21	4,343	20
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,188	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,910	20
11	Diana Shnaider	22	3,238	23
12	Maja Chwalinska	25	3,016	23
13	Iva Jovic	18	2,941	23
14	Elise Mertens	30	2,540	23
15	Sorana Cirstea	36	2,386	22

Top Indians



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 344 ▼ 10 spots



Vaidehee Chaudhari
Rank 392 ▲ 21 spots



English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Arsenal	9	8	0	1	14	5	9	24
2	Man. City	9	7	0	2	20	10	10	21
3	Brighton	9	6	1	2	24	7	17	19
4	Chelsea	9	5	1	3	19	15	4	16
5	Liverpool	9	4	3	2	11	9	2	15
6	Brentford	9	3	5	1	16	9	7	14
7	Everton	9	3	4	2	9	9	0	13
8	Bournemouth	9	3	3	3	14	13	1	12
9	Tottenham	9	3	3	3	10	10	0	12
10	Aston Villa	9	3	3	3	10	13	-3	12
11	Hull City	9	2	5	2	11	10	1	11
12	Leeds United	9	2	5	2	9	8	1	11
13	Newcastle	9	3	2	4	12	15	-3	11
14	Ipswich Town	9	3	2	4	14	18	-4	11
15	Fulham	9	2	3	4	9	11	-2	9
16	Coventry City	9	3	0	6	9	16	-7	9
17	Man. United	9	1	4	4	10	15	-5	7
18	Crystal Palace	9	2	1	6	9	21	-12	7
19	N. Forest	9	1	3	5	6	12	-6	6
20	Sunderland	9	1	2	6	7	17	-10	5

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Lazio	10	9	1	0	24	8	16	28
2	Inter Milan	10	8	1	1	26	13	13	25
3	Roma	10	7	3	0	28	10	18	24
4	Como	10	7	2	1	18	8	10	23
5	AC Milan	10	6	3	1	21	12	9	21
6	Frosinone	10	6	2	2	24	14	10	20
7	Juventus	10	5	2	3	13	10	3	17
8	Napoli	10	4	2	4	17	13	4	14
9	Bologna	10	4	2	4	14	13	1	14
10	Torino	10	4	1	5	14	16	-2	13
11	Genoa	10	4	1	5	10	14	-4	13
12	Cagliari	10	4	1	5	9	15	-6	13
13	Atalanta	10	3	2	5	16	20	-4	11
14	Lecce	10	3	0	7	11	21	-10	9
15	Parma	10	2	2	6	8	15	-7	8
16	Fiorentina	10	2	2	6	15	23	-8	8
17	Sassuolo	10	2	2	6	16	26	-10	8
18	Monza	10	2	1	7	17	24	-7	7
19	Udinese	10	1	2	7	11	23	-12	5
20	Venezia	10	1	0	9	6	20	-14	3

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Barcelona	11	10	0	1	46	12	34	30
2	Atletico Madrid	11	9	1	1	22	8	14	28
3	Real Madrid	11	9	0	2	28	10	18	27
4	Real Betis	11	7	2	2	18	15	3	23
5	Real Sociedad	11	6	1	4	20	20	0	19
6	Sevilla	11	5	2	4	17	19	-2	17
7	Athletic Club	10	4	3	3	14	10	4	15
8	Deportivo	11	3	5	3	15	14	1	14
9	Villarreal	11	3	3	5	15	15	0	12
10	Celta Vigo	11	2	6	3	10	10	0	12
11	Alaves	11	3	3	5	15	17	-2	12
12	Rayo Vallecano	10	3	3	4	15	20	-5	12
13	Getafe	11	3	3	5	8	16	-8	12
14	Espanyol	11	3	2	6	13	14	-1	11
15	Osasuna	11	3	2	6	11	22	-11	11
16	Racing Santander	11	3	2	6	15	29	-14	11
17	Elche	11	2	4	5	14	18	-4	10
18	Levante	11	2	4	5	16	21	-5	10
19	Valencia	11	2	3	6	8	17	-9	9
20	Malaga	11	0	5	6	8	21	-13	5

German Bundesliga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Bayern	8	5	3	0	27	8	19	18
2	Dortmund	8	5	3	0	14	6	8	18
3	SC Freiburg	8	5	1	2	18	10	8	16
4	RB Leipzig	8	5	0	3	22	11	11	15
5	Werder	8	4	3	1	17	14	3	15
6	Leverkusen	8	4	1	3	18	16	2	13
7	Elversberg	8	4	1	3	16	16	0	13
8	E. Frankfurt	8	3	2	3	13	18	-5	11
9	Mainz	8	3	1	4	17	17	0	10
10	FC Augsburg	8	2	3	3	18	15	3	9
11	Stuttgart	8	3	0	5	14	15	-1	9
12	Hoffenheim	8	3	0	5	14	16	-2	9
13	Cologne	8	2	3	3	9	12	-3	9
14	Paderborn	8	2	3	3	6	9	-3	9
15	Hamburg	8	3	0	5	7	19	-12	9
16	Union Berlin	8	1	4	3	7	19	-12	7
17	Schalke	8	1	3	4	4	9	-5	6
18	M'gladbach	8	1	1	6	11	22	-11	4



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Joe Root	816	932
3	Travis Head	799	884
4	Temba Bavuma	793	818
5	Steve Smith	790	947
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	881	881
2	Marco Jansen	875	876
3	Matt Henry	861	870
4	Ollie Robinson	856	856
5	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
6	Scott Boland	821	829
7	Simon Harmer	817	817
8	Pat Cummins	789	914
9	Kagiso Rabada	801	902
10	Josh Hazlewood	785	864

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	841	855
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	781	908
4	Rohit Sharma	770	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	752	756
6	Ben Duckett	733	733
7	Shai Hope	710	782
8	Harry Brook	674	693
9	Babar Azam	661	894
10	K.L. Rahul	653	676

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	760	775
2	Keshav Maharaj	660	737
3	Mitchell Santner	644	656
4	Abrar Ahmed	642	675
5	Shaheen Afridi	621	691
6	Kuldeep Yadav	620	757
7	A. Omarzai	610	610
8	Mehidy Hasan	597	722
9	Taskin Ahmed	595	595
9	Maheesh Theekshana	595	680

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abhishek Sharma	889	931
2	Sahibzada Farhan	883	883
3	Ishan Kishan	862	916
4	Harry Brook	793	793
5	Jos Buttler	789	794
5	Dewald Brevis	789	806
7	Shreyas Iyer	777	829
8	Phil Salt	775	881
9	Shai Hope	759	766
10	Pathum Nissanka	720	796

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	731	828
2	Adam Zampa	700	746
3	Adil Rashid	695	747
3	Abrar Ahmed	695	757
5	Mitchell Santner	676	735
6	Nathan Ellis	675	678
7	Jamie Overton	674	674
8	Nasum Ahmed	661	661
9	Mahedi Hasan	654	654
10	Liam Dawson	648	652

If you're fit and performing well, age doesn't matter

PHOTO: R.K. NITHIN



After spending years waiting for an international call-up, Michael Klinger sparkled in his brief stint with Australia. Now a sought-after coach on the franchise circuit, the 46-year-old reflects on opening with Brendon McCullum in the IPL, coaching Gujarat Giants in the WPL and ageism in cricket

INTERVIEW

Michael Klinger

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Michael Klinger made 62 for Australia in the third T20I against Sri Lanka at Adelaide in 2017. He did not play another international game. He scored 24,729 runs across First Class, List A and T20 matches. He is now a much-in-demand coach in different countries, including India, where he is training Gujarat Giants. Excerpts from an interview Klinger gave *The Hindu* at Kochi, the day after the WPL's mini auction:

For a side that finished at the bottom in the first two editions of the WPL, Gujarat Giants did rather well in the last two, qualifying for the playoffs back-to-back...

I inherited the team from the first year and then made some subtle changes. At the mega auction, we were able to make some big changes.

You retained just a couple of players from the previous squad – Beth Mooney and Ashleigh Gardner.

Yeah, we retained the two overseas.
But then we added what we felt were some really strong local players who probably hadn't made it big at that stage.

> It is a little bit harder now when you are working over three formats. It just takes time for any young player to master all three

You have been at the WPL since 2024...

I was really surprised in my first year to see how big the crowds were here in India. Everywhere you go, there is a really good following. The Indian women's team performing well in the World Cups and things like that have helped just to create a lot of interest in India. And we love playing in Gujarat at our home or even away in front of a lot of RCB fans... That is still good fun. Our girls get to play in front of big crowds. And that is what it is all about.

As a player, you had one season of the IPL, here in Kochi. You played for Kochi Tuskers Kerala in 2011.

I enjoyed my time here. I played with some great people, both Indian players and overseas players.

Like Brendon McCullum...

Yeah, yeah. I opened the batting with him a few times. He always had a good cricketing mind. When he was coaching Brisbane Heat, I was playing for Perth. It is good to see him doing well in the coaching space now.

As the England coach, what they needed was just to get some real interest back into Tests, with what people call Bazball, which the coach and the players didn't want to call. Their only downfall was just not being able to adapt and change their game slightly when it needed to be changed.

In the three T20Is you played for Australia, you made 38, 43 and 62. It must have been disappointing not to have been picked by Australia after that.

Not so much after that, because for that series, against Sri Lanka, Cricket Australia had rested David Warner and Steve Smith. Steve was a regular for Australia in T20Is then. So I sort of came in to fill that gap. And then the following series was not until six months later. We did not have that many games. By the time that happened, those two came back into the team. So I had a pretty good idea that that series was probably going to be my only one.



Before that, in a whole lot of different stages of my career, there were potential opportunities to play. And I was told I was close a few times. The frustration back then came before that Sri Lanka series, not so much after that. Even though I had a good series, I sort of knew that I was going to get replaced post that.

Now, when I look back, I am also extremely appreciative of the opportunities I had from the age of 18 to 39. Not many athletes can have 21 years of a professional career.

And 182 First Class matches.

Yes, I was very, very lucky. I would have loved to play more for Australia. But at the same time, I am very lucky to play the games that I did.

Were there times when you feared that you might never get a chance to play for Australia?

Yeah, I probably thought it was past me, to be honest. What probably helped me was that the series was played straight after a Big Bash where I personally had a good season. And we [Perth Scorchers] won the championship. And I think the team was picked a couple of days after a final in which I made 71 not out. So the timing worked pretty well that time to get that selection.

How did it feel getting that Australian cap finally?

I was extremely happy. But I was more happy for the people around me, my family, than myself. Because, they supported me for many, many years and through a few periods of disappointment, when I missed out on Australian teams. To see the smiles on their faces, when I told them that I was selected, and for them to be able to come and watch me because the matches were in Australia, those three games... I think that gave me more pleasure probably than myself playing.

And a young Travis Head was in that Australian team...

I captained him in his first game. For his first couple of seasons he played for South Australia and the Adelaide Strikers. In one of his first games, we had a partnership and we put on over 200. I think he got out for 98, unfortunately. We got along really well. I actually got him to Washington Freedom a few years ago when we won the [Major League Cricket] championship. From the start, you could see he had something special.

It took him a few years, as it does with any young player, just to work out his game and work out his strength. It is especially a little bit harder now when you are working over three formats as well. It just takes time for any young player just to master all three. And he has done it now. And he is a great person as well. Australia is very lucky to have him.

> We love playing in Gujarat at our home or even away in front of a lot of RCB fans... Our girls get to play in front of big crowds. And that is what it is all about

Do you think age is a bit overrated in international sport? Are selectors and administrators giving an athlete's age more importance than it deserves?

Yeah, I think so. If you are performing well, then I don't think age should be a criterion. Probably the two guys you look back to in Test cricket in Australia were Chris Rogers and Adam Voges. They came in their mid-30s – for Rogers, his second time.

They both did really well even if it was for a short period, but their contribution to the Australian Test team was great. So I think if a player is fit and healthy and they are contributing to the team, age doesn't really matter.

There is probably less leeway for the older players. If a 21-year-old misses out a few times with the bat, you know, maybe the media and selectors are not as harsh on them.

GAME THEORY

Finals bosses: prolific season-end champions

Ahead of the 2026 WTA Finals, set to get underway in Indian Wells on Sunday, we take a look at the greatest champions of the prestigious season-ender, which features the world's top eight singles players and doubles teams. Martina Navratilova, with an incredible 21 titles combined (8 singles, 13 doubles), has dominated the event, widely considered the most significant tournament on the calendar after the four Majors.

MOST SINGLES TITLES

Player	Titles	Editions
Martina Navratilova	8	1978-79, 81, 83-86(2)
Steffi Graf	5	1987, 89, 93, 95-96
Serena Williams	5	2001, 09, 12-14
Chris Evert	4	1972-73, 75, 77
Monica Seles	3	1990-92
Kim Clijsters	3	2002-03, 10
Evonne Goolagong Cawley	2	1974, 76
Gabriela Sabatini	2	1988, 94
Martina Hingis	2	1998, 2000
Justine Henin	2	2006-07

MOST DOUBLES TITLES

Player	Titles	Editions
Martina Navratilova	13	1977-78, 80-86, 87-89, 91
Pam Shriver	10	1981-86, 87-89, 91
Billie Jean King	4	1974, 76, 78, 80
Lisa Raymond	4	2001, 05-06, 11
Betty Stove	3	1976-77, 79
Natasha Zvereva	3	1993-94, 98
Lindsay Davenport	3	1996-98
Liezel Huber	3	2007-08, 11
Cara Black	3	2007-08, 14
Martina Hingis	3	1999-00, 2015
Timea Babos	3	2017-19

SOURCE: WTA TOUR | NOTE: THE EVENT WAS HELD TWICE IN 1986 BECAUSE OF A CHANGE OF SCHEDULE



MARTINA NAVRATILOVA



STEFFI GRAF



SERENA WILLIAMS



PAM SHRIVER

PICTURE THIS



GETTY IMAGES

Down time

Horses Suntora and Haaracaine are put through a sunrise recovery session on the beach in Altona North, Australia, in this photograph.

Much like elite human athletes, racehorses, too, need structured training programmes tailored to their strengths, weaknesses and tendencies, and designed to build them up to a race.

Much of the training is done early in the morning to prevent heat exhaustion, especially in places where the temperatures can soar as the day wears on. Recovery is essential, as well.

According to *Horse Racing Sense*, "training sessions include walking, trotting, galloping, and working (running)". This can involve slow work on the sand track, rides around the local paddock, walks on an automatic walking machine and swimming sessions in the pool or, where possible, a more natural water setting. Racehorses also need to be around other horses and different environments as a part of their preparation for competition. Unless properly acclimatised, they can get nervous, sweat profusely (a phenomenon known as 'washing out') and underperform in a race.